

THE HANDOVER

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A NOVEL

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O N E

NIDD

The meeting rooms on floor six were named after rivers, and the one nobody wanted was Nidd.

It was not clear why. Nidd was the same as the others, a glass box with a table in it and a screen on the wall that took eleven minutes to find a laptop, and it had the same view of the multi-storey and the same brown carpet tile. But there was a feeling about Nidd. People booked Wharfe first and then Aire and then Calder, and they booked Nidd when there was nothing else, and they said sorry, it's Nidd, in the tone of a man apologising for the pub he has chosen. Cowie had once floated the theory that it was the name, that the sound of it, the flatness, the one closed syllable, made people think of a wet afternoon, and Marcus had looked at him for a while and then said that this was the single most Neil thing he had ever heard.

He was in Nidd now, and had been since half past nine, because the spring range review was in eleven days and nobody outside the category team understood what that meant.

What it meant was this. Three times a year the business reasoned about its shelves from first principles. Every product in every aisle had to justify its existence against every product that wanted to replace it, and the justification was arithmetic, and the arithmetic was harder than anybody believed. Rate of sale, margin, cannibalisation, the difference between what a customer bought and what a customer said they bought, which was the

whole of Cowie's professional life and, he suspected, quite a lot of everything else. He had two hundred and six pages of it open in front of him. He had a printout, because he thought better on paper, and Marcus had made a joke about that too.

The fight this quarter was over eleven centimetres.

Eleven centimetres of the bottom shelf, gained by taking a facing off a national brand that had been coasting for two years on a television advert with a dog in it, and Cowie wanted to give the eleven centimetres to a company in Ripon that made a hand-cooked crisp in a bag the colour of a hedge. He had modelled it four ways. He had a slide. He had, and he was not proud of this, rehearsed the slide in the car.

"It won't fly," said Marcus, from the doorway, with his coat already on at twenty to five. "Kerrigan will kill it."

"Kerrigan hasn't seen the four-way."

"Kerrigan doesn't need to see the four-way. Kerrigan needs to see that you're taking a facing off a brand that spent nine million quid last year."

"On a dog."

"On a dog," Marcus agreed, "that people love." He put his bag on his shoulder. "Go home, Neil. It's Tuesday."

Cowie did not go home. He stayed until twenty past six, alone on floor six with the lights going off in sections behind him as the sensors gave up, and he took the eleven centimetres apart one more time and put them back together, and at the end of it he was still right. He was aware that being right was not the same as winning and that the gap between those two things was where most people's working lives were spent. He had made a kind of peace with that. He was thirty-one. He had another thirty-four years of this and he had decided, at some point he could not identify, that he did not mind.

On the way out he passed Sue Ellerby at the printer.

Sue was in facilities and had been in the building for thirty years, which meant she had been in it before the company was the company, when it had been two other companies with different names and a different arrangement of walls. She knew where the stopcocks were. She knew

which of the fire doors on four had been sticking since 2009 and had a running argument about it with a contractor who came twice a year. She was retiring in three weeks and there was a card going round that Cowie had already signed, in blue, *All the best, Neil C*, because he had signed a hundred of those and he had a system.

"They've put me in the ballroom at the Queens," she said, with enormous disgust. "For a buffet."

"That's nice."

"It's not nice, love. I asked for the Adelphi." She squared her printouts on her hip. "Thirty years and a buffet in a ballroom. I'd rather have the money."

"You could ask for the money."

Sue looked at him with real warmth, the way you look at a child who has said something structurally sound.

"You could ask for the money," she said. "That's what I like about you lot. You think there's a form."

. . . .

He drove home along Kirkstall Road with the radio on and did not hear the item, or heard it and did not attend, which he would think about later in a way that did him no good at all. There was a thing about a hospital in the north east. There was a phrase, *a small number of cases*, which was the kind of phrase that slid off the ear because it had been engineered to. Then there was the traffic, and then there was the sport.

The flat was the top half of a terrace with a view of a wall. He had been in it four years. It was too big for one person by exactly one room, and the room was full of things he had meant to deal with: a bike with a flat tyre, a box of his father's records, a flat-pack shelf unit that had defeated him twice and that he had begun to think of as an opponent.

He made the good pasta, the one with the anchovies, and ate it standing up.

At half nine Jo rang.

"Are you eating standing up?"

"No."

"You are. I can hear the counter." His sister was twenty-seven and lived two streets away and had a gift, which he had spent his life resenting and relying on in equal measure, for identifying the precise shape of his evening from four hundred yards. "Neil. Are you coming Sunday or not?"

"I said I'd come."

"You said you'd let me know. Which is what you say when you're deciding whether to have a headache."

He looked at the wall. "I'm coming."

"Because Mum's asking, and I can't keep saying he's busy, because she knows what you do for a living, and she doesn't think it's busy."

"It's very busy."

"It's crisps, Neil."

"It's a hundred and forty million pounds of crisps."

"Right," said Jo, "and none of it's yours," which was the kind of thing she said and then immediately regretted, and he could hear the regret arrive, and he let her sit in it for a second because that was the arrangement they had.

Then she said, in a different voice, "Have you seen this thing on the news?"

"What thing?"

"Newcastle. Or Sunderland. There's a hospital's gone into some kind of lockdown and nobody's saying why, and there's a nurse on Twitter who's said something and then taken it down."

"Taken what down?"

"That's the thing. She's taken it down." A pause. He could hear her television going in the other room. "It's probably nothing."

"It's probably nothing," Cowie said.

They stayed on the phone another twenty minutes talking about their mother's boiler, and about a man Jo had been seeing and had stopped seeing, and about whether Cowie was going to do anything about the shelf unit, and at the end of it she said see you Sunday and he said see you

Sunday, and that was the last entirely ordinary conversation of his life, and neither of them noticed it going past.

. . . .

He lay in bed and thought about the eleven centimetres.

This was the part he never told anybody, because it sounded like a joke about a small man with a small life, and he understood how it sounded. But there was a man in Ripon called Adrian who ran the crisp company with his brother-in-law, and Adrian had come down to Leeds in September in a suit that did not fit him and had sat in Wharfe, not Nidd, Cowie had made sure of that, and had talked for forty minutes about potatoes with the particular fluency of a person who has organised his entire life around one thing. And at the end Cowie had asked what the listing would mean, and Adrian had said, without any performance in it at all, that it would mean two more on the line.

Two people. Two actual people, in Ripon, who would be doing something on a Monday morning that they were not currently doing, because of eleven centimetres on a bottom shelf, because of a four-way model built by a man in a glass box named after a river.

That was the job. Nobody believed it was the job, including his sister, including his mother, including Marcus. But it was, and he was good at it, and in eleven days he was going to walk into a room and take a facing off a dog.

He fell asleep at about half eleven.

Somewhere in the north east, in a hospital that would be named in every account of what followed and that none of them would ever see, a consultant had by then been awake for thirty-one hours and had begun writing an email that he would not send, because at four in the morning the person he had been writing it about got up off a trolley and it stopped being the kind of thing you put in an email.

T W O

ELEVEN DAYS

Afterwards, when people talked about it, they remembered an afternoon.

They remembered a single afternoon in which the world had turned over, and Cowie could never make anybody believe that it had not been like that, that there had been eleven days, and that the eleven days had been the worst part, because during the eleven days it had still been possible to be embarrassed.

He had a way of proving it, and nobody ever wanted the proof.

The proof was the data. On Wednesday morning, the day after Jo rang about the nurse who had taken her post down, Cowie opened the daily sales report the way he opened it every morning, with a coffee, out of habit, the way another man reads the football, and he saw that tinned tomatoes had done four hundred and eleven per cent.

He sat and looked at it for a while.

Four hundred and eleven per cent is not a number that occurs. A good week is nine. A promotion with a television spot behind it and a bank holiday is thirty. Four hundred and eleven per cent is not a consumer behaviour, it is a fault in the system, and so Cowie's first act, on the first true morning of the end of the world, was to raise a ticket with data services asking them to check the feed.

Data services replied at 11:04 to say the feed was fine.

He went and stood at the window on floor six and looked down at Wellington Street, at the traffic, at a man carrying a coffee and a laptop bag,

at the multi-storey with its top deck half empty the way it always was, and he understood that somewhere out beyond that, in the ordinary shops of the north of England, a very large number of people had all had the same idea at the same time and had not told each other they were having it. Nobody had panicked. Nobody had said the word. Everybody had simply thought, on their own, privately, on the way past, *I might just get a few tins in.*

That was the thing about the eleven days. The country was not frightened. The country was quietly, individually, deniably getting a few tins in.

. . . .

By Friday it was rice and paracetamol.

By Monday it was bottled water, which he had modelled a hundred times and which had never once behaved like that, and the depot at Wakefield had stopped taking orders and started allocating, and Cowie spent an entire day on a call about whether allocation should be by store size or by historic rate of sale, and he argued for historic rate of sale, and he won, and he has never been able to decide since whether that was the last honest piece of work he ever did or the worst.

The advice remained unchanged. That was the phrase, and it came at six, and it came from a man with grey at the temples standing at a lectern with a slogan on it, and the slogan changed twice in the eleven days, which Cowie noticed because noticing that kind of thing was his job.

The schools stayed open, then some of them did not, then the ones that had closed said they would reopen Monday. A football match was played behind closed doors and there was an argument about it, a real argument, with two sides, conducted at length on the radio. Somebody in the office said the word overreaction on the Tuesday and it went round the floor like a warm coat, and everybody put it on, and for about a day and a half floor six was a very calm place to be.

Kerrigan cancelled the range review on the Wednesday and reinstated it on the Thursday.

And underneath it, all week, there were the other reports, the ones that did not come from lecterns. A man on the internet with a video of a car park in Sunderland. A nurse, a different nurse, who had not taken hers down. Jo sent him a link at one in the morning and then sent a second message that said *don't watch that* and he watched it and it was eleven seconds long and it was filmed through a window, and afterwards he sat on the edge of his bed in the dark for a long time and then went and checked that his front door was locked, and then went back to bed, and then got up and checked it again.

That was the ninth day. He still went to work on the tenth.

. . .

Sue Ellerby's retirement do was on the Wednesday evening, day ten, in the ballroom at the Queens, and about a third of the people who had said yes came.

There was a buffet. There was a card, the one he had signed, and a collection that had made four hundred and eighty pounds, and a speech by Kerrigan that had clearly been written by somebody else and that used the phrase *institutional memory* twice. Sue stood next to him with a glass of warm white wine and listened to it with an expression Cowie had never seen on her before, and afterwards, when the clapping had gone on slightly too long and then stopped all at once, she said:

"They've asked me to stop on."

"To stop on?"

"Three months. Because of all this." She waved the glass at *all this*, at the ballroom, at the third of a room, at the country. "Kerrigan asked me in the taxi. In the taxi, Neil."

"What did you say?"

"I said I'd think about it." She drank some of the wine and made a face at it. "Thirty years. And it turns out the only thing they actually wanted was for me to know where the stopcocks are."

He should have said something. He has thought about it since, at length, in a stairwell, in a barn, on a landing with a door chocked open behind him. There were a dozen things available and every one of them would have been better than what he did say, which was:

"You could always ask for the money."

Sue laughed. That is the part he keeps. She laughed properly, with her head back, and said, "Oh, love," and put her hand flat on his arm for a second, and went off to talk to somebody from accounts, and he got a taxi at half nine because he had an early call.

. . . .

Jo rang on the way home.

"Where are you?"

"In a cab. Sue's leaving do."

"Neil, there's a thing outside Mum's."

He sat up. "What kind of thing."

"An ambulance and two police cars and they've got the end of the road with tape. Mum's fine, I've spoken to her, she's fine, she's inside, she's got the chain on." Jo's voice was doing something he had heard perhaps three times in his life. "But they've been there four hours and nobody will say anything and there's a bloke from the council in a van just sat there."

"Have you been over?"

"They won't let you down the road."

The taxi went along Kirkstall Road past the retail park. There was a queue at the petrol station that went out onto the carriageway and a man in a hi-vis walking down the line of cars saying something to each of them in turn, and Cowie watched him get to the fourth car and watched the fourth car pull out of the queue and drive away.

"Jo," he said. "Come and stop at mine tomorrow."

"I've got work."

"Come after work then."

"Have you seen the roads?"

"Come after work," he said, and she said all right, and she meant it, and if she had come after work on the Thursday instead of going home first to get a bag then everything that happened in the next two years would have happened differently, and Cowie has done that arithmetic more times than he has done any other arithmetic in his life, including the four-way model, including the eleven centimetres.

He went to bed at midnight on the tenth day. He set an alarm for six.

The alarm went off. That is what he tells people, when he tells anybody, which is almost never. It is the detail that does it. The alarm went off, on the morning of the last ordinary day, and he got up and had a shower and put on a shirt, and drove into town, and parked on the fourth level of the multi-storey because the third was full, and swiped through the barrier, and got into the lift with a man from legal, and said morning, and went up to floor six to do a range review for a spring that was not going to happen.

THREE

THE HANDOVER

There were three of them in Nidd, which was itself the sign, if anyone had been reading signs.

Kerrigan was not there. Marcus was not there. Half the floor was not there, and the half that was there had arrived to find an all-staff email from a director nobody had heard of saying that the business was monitoring the situation and that colleagues should continue to attend their place of work as normal unless advised otherwise by their line manager. Cowie's line manager was Marcus. Marcus's phone was going to voicemail.

So he had gone into Nidd at nine with two people who had also not been advised otherwise: a woman called Deb from finance who was covering for somebody, and a graduate whose name Cowie is ashamed to say he could not afterwards recall, a lad of about twenty-two in a very good jacket who had been on the team eleven weeks and who kept saying *no worries* in a way that suggested a great many worries.

They went through the review. They actually went through it. Deb had the margin figures and the graduate had the planogram open on the screen that took eleven minutes to find a laptop, and Cowie stood at the whiteboard with a marker and made the case for the eleven centimetres to a room containing two people, neither of whom had any authority over it, one of whom was there by accident.

He was good. That is the awful thing. He was as good as he had ever been. Deb asked the obvious question about cannibalisation and he had

the answer, and she asked the second, better question underneath it and he had that too, and there was a moment at about twenty past ten, standing at a whiteboard in a glass box named after a river, when Neil Cowie was doing the finest work of his professional life in front of an audience of two who would both be dead within nine days.

At half past eleven the graduate's phone went.

He looked at it and said no worries, and then he looked at it again and stood up so fast that his chair went over backwards, and he went out through the glass door with the phone at his ear saying Mum, Mum, where are you, and he did not come back, and Cowie never learned his name and has tried, since, in the small hours, to reconstruct it from the seating plan, and cannot.

Deb sat very still. Then she said, "I think that's it, isn't it."

"I think we should probably wrap up," said Cowie.

He heard himself say it. He hears himself say it still. *Wrap up*. It was twenty-five to twelve on the last day of the world and he had reached for the phrase you use when a meeting has run long.

. . .

Floor six emptied in about nine minutes.

There was no announcement. Somebody's radio was on at the far end, on the bank of desks by the window, tuned to a local station, and the local station had stopped doing music. People stood up in ones and twos and got their coats and did not clear their desks, because clearing your desk would have been admitting something, and everybody had decided independently that this was a going home early situation and not a not coming back situation, and so the floor was left exactly as it stood: cardigans on chairs, a lunch in the fridge, a spreadsheet open on a screen with the cursor blinking in cell F41.

Cowie put his coat on. He turned off the whiteboard lights, which were on a separate switch, because that was the kind of thing he did.

At the lift he met Sue Ellerby coming the other way with a clipboard.

"You off?" she said.

"I think so. Are you?"

"I've got to do the roof plant." She said it as though he had asked something faintly stupid. "There's nobody else knows how to isolate it."

"Sue."

"It'll take twenty minutes."

He stood there with his coat on and his bag on his shoulder and the lift doors open behind him, and there was a version of that moment available to him in which he said the true thing, which was: *nobody is coming to check the roof plant, and nobody is going to, and I do not think there will be a building.* And he did not say it, because it was twenty to twelve on a Thursday and saying it would have been mad, and because Sue Ellerby had been isolating the roof plant since before he could drive.

"Right," he said. "See you tomorrow, then."

"See you tomorrow, love."

. . . .

He walked. The car was on the fourth level of the multi-storey and he got as far as the entrance to the ramp and saw that the ramp was solid, three lanes of it stopped dead with people leaning on their horns, and so he turned round and walked, and it was, and he has never known what to do with this, a beautiful day.

It was the second week of April and the sun was properly out for the first time that year, the particular hard clean light you get in the north when the wind has gone round, and the cherry trees on the way up past the university were doing the thing they do for about four days. There were people on the grass. There were, he swears to this, two lads playing frisbee.

And then the traffic was wrong. Not stopped: wrong. Everything on the inner ring road was going one way and going too fast and it did not thin out, it kept coming, and at the junction by the retail park a police car sat across two lanes with its lights on and nobody in it.

That was where the thought arrived.

He was walking past the retail park with the sun on his face and a queue of cars going the other way and a helicopter somewhere behind him that had been there for an hour, and a thought came into his head fully formed and unbidden and entirely his own, and the thought was:

Well, that's the range review off.

He stopped walking. He stood on the pavement outside a carpet warehouse and understood, with complete clarity, that some part of him was relieved.

Not glad. He has held the line on that ever since, in the reception centre, in the barn, in the small hours on the roof at Quarry Hill with Sandhu not asking him anything. Not glad. But there had been thirty-four more years of Nidd, and he had made his peace with them, and the peace had cost more than he had let himself know, and now a helicopter was going round and round over Burley and the thirty-four years had been taken off the table by something that was not his fault and that he had not had to choose.

He was ashamed of it for about four seconds. Then he started walking again, faster, because he had remembered his sister.

. . .

He saw his first one on Cardigan Road, forty minutes later, and it was nothing like the eleven seconds of video.

It was a woman in her sixties in a green coat, standing on the pavement outside a hairdresser's, facing the window. That was all. She was just standing there, close to the glass, the way you stand when you are reading a price list. Cowie was on the other side of the road and he slowed down, because there was something about the stillness, and he watched her for perhaps ten seconds, and in those ten seconds she did not move at all, not her head, not her hands, nothing, and it was that, the absolute absence of the small movements a person makes, that put the cold through him before he had understood anything.

Then a bus went past between them, and when it had gone she was facing him.

She had not turned. That is what he could never get across afterwards. There had been no turn, no swing of the head, no moment of noticing; there had been a bus, and then there had been a woman in a green coat facing the other way, and the whole of the change had happened in the two seconds he could not see.

She came off the kerb without checking the road, and a van hit her.

The van did not stop. It was doing perhaps thirty and it took her sideways and she went down and under, and the van kept going, and Cowie stood in the middle of Cardigan Road with his bag on his shoulder and his mouth open and watched the woman in the green coat get her arms underneath herself on the tarmac, with her hip at an angle a hip does not go, and start to get up.

He ran. He does not remember deciding to. He remembers the sound of his own bag hitting his back, over and over, and the smell of the cherry blossom, which was everywhere that week, and which he has not been able to be near since.

FOUR

THE MAN AT 47

He did not reach the woman in the green coat, because a man in a Passat did, and Cowie stopped ten yards short and watched what a car does when it is trying to make sure.

Then he went the long way round, up past the school and along the back of the allotments, and by the time he came out at the top of his own street it was ten past two and something had changed in the air of the city, some pressure difference, the way it goes before rain. There was a great deal of noise a long way off and no noise at all nearby. Every car was still on its drive.

Number 47 was four doors down from his. The man who lived there was called Emeka Ogunremi and he had a Volvo he cleaned on Sundays and a daughter at Manchester and a habit, which had irritated Cowie for four years, of putting his bins out on Tuesday night for a Thursday collection.

He was in his front garden, sitting against the low wall, with his legs straight out in front of him on the path.

"Neil," he said.

There was a lot of blood. It had come from his forearm and gone down into his lap and there was a good deal of it on the path, and the shape of it on the path told you the story, that he had been standing when it started and had got as far as the wall and had sat down because sitting down had seemed like the sensible thing.

Cowie went in through the gate.

"Don't," said Ogunremi.

"Let me look at it."

"Neil. Don't." He had his other hand clamped over it. He was grey around the mouth. "There's one in my house."

Cowie stopped on the path. The front door of number 47 was open and the hall was dim and there was nothing in it that he could see.

"Who is it?"

"It's Ruth." Ogunremi's wife. She had a way of saying good morning that made you feel you had been caught doing something. "She was poorly all yesterday. She was poorly and then she was up in the night and I couldn't get anyone. I rang three times." He was talking in a flat quick way, as if he had somewhere to be. "She's in the back. I've shut the door but there's no key on the back room, we never had a key on the back room."

"Right," said Cowie. "Right. I'm going to get you to a hospital."

"You're not going to get me anywhere."

"I've got a car."

"You've got a car on the fourth floor of a multi-storey," said Ogunremi, who had, Cowie realised, been watching him leave for work for four years the way Cowie had been watching him put his bins out.

There was a silence. In the silence there was a sound from inside the house, upstairs, a single soft thump, like a book going over.

"That's not Ruth," said Ogunremi.

Neither of them said anything about that.

"Emeka. Tell me what to do."

The man against the wall looked at him for a moment with an expression Cowie has spent two years trying to name and has settled, without satisfaction, on kindness.

"Go and get your sister," he said.

. . .

Here is what Cowie did.

He said, "I'll come back." He said it twice, and the second time he said it with his hand on the gate, already half turned, and Emeka Ogunremi said, "Aye," in the way people from that street said aye, meaning *no, and we both know it, and it is all right*.

Then Cowie walked four doors down to his own house and let himself in and stood in the hall with his back against the door.

He was in there eleven minutes. He knows the number because he looked at the clock in the kitchen when he came in and looked at it again when he went out. In those eleven minutes he did the following things. He filled a bag. He put in a coat, a phone charger, four tins, a bread knife because it was the biggest thing in the block and he could not make himself take the actual knives, his passport, and, for reasons that have never been available to him, his father's records, one single record, the Ella Fitzgerald, which he carried for nine days and eventually left in a hedge outside Otley.

He did not go back out to the front garden. He went out of the back, over the wall into the ginnel, because the ginnel came out at the top of Jo's street.

He heard it start about ninety seconds later, from two streets away, and it did not last long, and he kept walking.

. . . .

That is the first death Cowie saw, and it was not the woman in the green coat, because the woman in the green coat had already been something else by the time the van hit her. Emeka Ogunremi is the first, and he is the one Cowie would go back for, if the arrangement of the universe permitted one, which it does not.

He has been through it. He has been through it in the way you go through a thing at four in the morning, and he can build a case for himself. He had no vehicle. He had no medical training and no tourniquet and no way of making a tourniquet that would have held on a forearm. The bleeding was arterial or near enough. There was a second one in the house and a third one upstairs. He was thirty-one years old, he had been at work

that morning arguing about crisps, and no part of his life had prepared him to walk into a dim hallway with a bread knife he had not yet bought himself the right to hold.

All of that is true, and Sandhu, when he finally told her, on the roof at Quarry Hill, said the sensible thing, which was that a dead Cowie in a hall on Cardigan Road would have helped nobody, and that she had made four decisions in the first week that were worse.

But that is not the part.

The part is that Emeka Ogunremi told him to go and get his sister, and Cowie went into his own house first, for eleven minutes, and packed a bag, and one of the things he put in the bag was a record.

He did not run to Jo's. He walked, at a good pace, so as not to attract attention.

That was already the second rule, and it was two hours old, and everybody in the city had worked it out at the same time in the way they had all worked out about the tins. Do not run. Running is a shape that carries. Sound and movement, and of the two, movement. They stand still until something happens, and then they come, and they do not stop coming, and they are not fast but they are absolutely steady, and a man who is running will be seen by four of them and a man who is walking will be seen by one.

Cowie walked. Two streets. It took six minutes.

He was thinking, the whole way, about what he would say to Jo when she opened the door, and he settled on *don't argue, just get your coat*, and he was pleased with it, and rehearsed it twice, the way he had rehearsed the slide in the car.

She did not open the door.

TWO STREETS

She did not open the door because she was under the sink.

He got in through the kitchen window, which had a catch that had been broken since she moved in and which he had promised twice to fix, and she came out from the cupboard under the sink with a pan in her hand and hit him with it, hard, across the shoulder, before she understood who he was.

Then she held onto him for a while and neither of them said anything.

"There's one on the stairs," she said, when she could. "It's been on the stairs since one o'clock. It's Ryan from the top flat. I've heard him go up and down about forty times."

"Is your door locked?"

"Of course my door's locked, I'm not an idiot." She wiped her face with the back of her wrist. She had a bag on the table, half packed, in the way of somebody who has been packing for two hours and taking things out again. "Neil, I can't get Mum. I've been ringing since eleven."

"I know."

"The line does a thing. It doesn't ring, it does a thing, like a—"

"I know. I've had it too."

She looked at him and he watched her decide not to ask the question, and put it away somewhere for later, for a later that did not arrive.

"Right," she said. "So what's the plan."

. . .

The plan was Otley.

It was not much of a plan. It was the plan because their uncle Ray had a static caravan on a site outside Otley, and because Otley was fourteen miles, and because at three in the afternoon on the first day everybody in the north of England was making a plan out of whatever they had, and what the Cowies had was a caravan with a chemical toilet and a key under a brick.

They went out through the kitchen window because of Ryan on the stairs, and dropped into the yard, and got up onto the wall and along the back of the block, and it was fine. That is the thing nobody puts in the accounts. For two and a half hours it was fine. They walked up through Burley and out along the back roads with a bag each, past a chip shop with the lights on and nobody in it, past a primary school with the gates open and every window shut, past a man loading a Corsa so full that he had already lost the argument and would not admit it, and he nodded at them and they nodded at him.

Jo talked the whole way. That was how she was frightened. She talked about their mother's boiler and about the man she had stopped seeing and about whether Ray's caravan had a generator, and she made two jokes that were genuinely good, and Cowie remembers laughing on the Leeds ring road on the afternoon of the first day.

They came off the road at Horsforth to get round a queue, down a snicket between two houses, and there were four of them in the snicket.

. . .

What happened in the next fifteen seconds is the thing that Cowie can slow down and cannot change.

He went first. That is one of the two facts he holds on to, and it is worth about as much as an eleven-minute alibi. He went first, into the narrow bit, and the first one came at him off the wall and he got his forearm up and it went past him, because they are not clever, they go where they were going, and he shoved it into the fence and the fence went over.

Then he turned round and Jo was on the floor.

She had gone backwards over a bin. She was on her back with one of them across her legs and it had her by the thigh, and Cowie got the bread knife into the side of its head, which is not where you put it, and it did not stop, so he got it in the eye, which is, and it did stop, and the two of them dragged her out of the snicket by her arms with the other two coming on behind, steady, not hurrying.

Two hundred yards up the road there was a launderette with the door open. They got in and got the door shut and put a machine against it.

Jo's jeans were black with it before he had her leg up on the folding table.

"How bad," she said. "Neil. How bad."

He got the fabric back. It was the inside of the thigh, high, and it was pumping, and he knew from a first aid course he had done for work in 2016, in a room called Wharfe, with a plastic torso and a woman with a laminated card, that this was the one you could not fix.

"It's all right," he said.

"Neil."

"It's all right. Give me your belt."

He did everything he had been taught in a meeting room by a woman with a laminated card. He put the belt round the top of her leg and turned it with a mop handle until she screamed at him, and he put his whole weight on the wound through her jacket, and he held it, and he counted, because the woman had said you count, and he got to four hundred and something and lost his place and started again.

It slowed. He believed for a while that it had stopped.

He talked at her the entire time. He does not know what about. He knows that at one point he was telling her about the eleven centimetres, about Adrian in Ripon and the bag the colour of a hedge and the two more on the line, because it was the only thing in his head that was not the launderette, and Jo said, with her eyes shut, "That's a nice one. Tell that one at the caravan."

She was lucid nearly to the end, which he had not expected, and which he now knows is normal, and which is worse.

At about half five she said, "You have to do it after."

"Do what."

"Neil."

He said nothing.

"You've seen them," she said. "You've seen one today, you told me, on the road. So you know that in about an hour I'm going to get up off this table, and I need you to not let me do that, because it will not be me, and I am not having that. I'm not having it." Her voice had gone very reasonable, which was how she got when she had decided something. "There's a fire extinguisher on the wall by the till."

"Stop it."

"I've looked at it for an hour. It's the red one, it's heavy enough, and you want to do it from behind, up here, so you're not—" she moved two fingers a small distance, and could not finish, and then finished. "So you're not looking at me."

"Jo."

"Say you will."

He said he would.

That is the second fact he holds on to, and it is worth less than the first, because it was a lie at the moment he said it and both of them knew it. She looked at him for a long moment with the last of what she had, and she did not say *you won't*, because she was better than him, and had been the whole time, and had known it since she was about nine.

She said, "Don't watch, then."

She died at four minutes past seven. He knows because there was a clock over the service counter and he looked at it, because he had looked at a clock in his own hallway at ten past two, and it turns out that when there is nothing else to be done a certain kind of man will keep the time.

He sat on the floor of the launderette with his back against a machine for eleven minutes.

Eleven again. He is aware of that. Sandhu, who is not sentimental, once suggested that he has rounded both of them to the same number over two years of telling himself the story, and that this is the mind tidying up, and that he should let it. He has not let it.

At the end of the eleven minutes he stood up and went to the wall by the till and took down the extinguisher, and it was heavy, heavier than it looked, and he carried it back across the launderette and stood at the end of the folding table with it in both hands.

His sister had been dead for a quarter of an hour and was beginning to be something else. Her hand had moved. Not a twitch: a movement, deliberate, the fingers finding the edge of the table the way your hand finds the edge of the bed in the dark.

He put the extinguisher down on the floor.

He went out of the back of the launderette into a yard full of pallets, and got over a fence, and walked away up a hill in the dusk, and behind him in the empty shop the thing that had his sister's hand got itself up off the folding table at some point that night and began the slow business of finding the door.

He did not go back. There has never been a day since when some part of him was not walking back down that hill.

THE A65

He was on his own for nine days and he does not talk about them.

Not out of trauma, or not only. It is that there is nothing in them worth anybody's time. He walked, and hid, and drank out of a garden tap on the third day and was ill for two, and slept in a Portakabin on a building site, and in a church porch, and once, badly, in a hedge. He ate what was in the bag and then he ate what was in a Spar in Guiseley that three other people had already been through, which was a jar of gherkins, a bag of pine nuts and eleven Fruit Corners. He did not speak to anybody. He saw people. Twice he saw people and got off the road before they saw him, and the second time he lay in a ditch and watched four adults and a dog go past and he had no reason at all to think they were dangerous, and he has never been able to decide whether that was the sensible thing or the beginning of something in him that he does not like.

On the fifth day the electricity went. He noticed it because a house he was passing had been playing a radio into an empty kitchen for three days, and then it was not.

On the seventh day the leaflets came. An aircraft went over low at about six in the morning and let them go in a long spill, and they came down over four fields and a wood and the roof of a garden centre, and Cowie picked one out of a hedge. It was A5, printed both sides, and it was headed NATIONAL RECOVERY EXECUTIVE and it said that the Handover was in its final phase.

He read that sentence about nine times.

The Handover. Somebody, somewhere, in a building with the power still on, had sat down in front of a blank page with the end of the country in front of them and had chosen that word, and then a second person had approved it, and then it had gone to print, and the leaflet had a second colour in it, which meant a decision had been made about the second colour.

The rest of it was directions. Citizens were to make their way to designated Reception at listed locations. The nearest listed location was Harrogate. There was a map that showed no roads, only the locations, floating in white, which meant that the map had been designed by somebody who had never had to get anywhere.

He put the leaflet in his coat. He still has it.

On the ninth day, outside Otley, he took the Ella Fitzgerald out of the bag and put it in a hedge, and stood there for a bit, and then went on.

. . . .

The A65 was where the plan failed, and it failed because of the arithmetic that had failed everywhere: everybody had the same idea at the same time and did not tell each other.

Every leaflet in the north had a Reception on it. Every Reception was north or east. Everybody who could still walk was going one of two ways along one of four roads, and the four roads were also where the vehicles were, the ones that had run out of fuel or road and been left, and the vehicles were where people had slept, and where people had slept was where the rest of it went.

Cowie came down onto the A65 at about four in the afternoon and it was a river of them.

Not a crowd. He wants that understood, because the word people use is crowd and it is wrong. A crowd has edges and it mills. This had a direction. It came up the road from the Leeds end at a walking pace and it did not thin, and the front of it was already past the roundabout and the back of it

was not in sight, and it moved with the terrible even patience of water finding a level, and it was, at a conservative count, a thousand of them and probably more.

They were going towards Harrogate.

He has thought about that a great deal since. The Executive's own leaflet, the second colour, the map with no roads. Somebody's aircraft had spent three days telling everybody in the region where to walk, and about a quarter of the people who set off had not made it, and the ones who had not made it had got up again and carried on in the direction they had been given.

There was a Transit on the verge with two flat tyres. He got underneath it.

He was under that van for eleven hours.

. . . .

He was not alone under it, which he did not discover for the first forty minutes, because she was at the other end behind the wheel arch and she had been there since the morning and she had the sense not to move.

At about five, in the noise, a voice said, quite conversationally, "Don't wriggle. They see wriggling."

Cowie put his face in the grit and said, "Right."

"Are you bit?"

"No."

"Are you sure? People are wrong about that."

"I'm sure."

"Right," she said, and that was the whole of the conversation for two hours.

Her name was Priti Sandhu and she was a PE teacher from Bradford, and by the time it was fully dark they had established that neither of them was going to be able to hold their bladder for another eleven hours and had agreed a protocol about it, and by two in the morning they had told each other everything, in the way you do when you are lying on your face in the

dark under a vehicle with a thousand of them going past six feet away and you have decided you are going to die.

He told her about the launderette. First person he told, four days later he could not have said why. She listened to all of it and did not say any of the things people say.

Then she said, "I've got two boys in Southampton."

"Have you heard from them?"

"No," said Sandhu, and then, after a while, "They're twenty-two and twenty-five. They'll be fine." And then, later, in a different voice, "That's what I'm going with."

They came out at five in the morning onto a road that looked as though a war had crossed it, and Sandhu stood up, and put her hands in the small of her back, and said, "Right. Not that way, then."

. . .

They picked the rest of them up over nine days, going west, which was the direction nobody had been given.

Hutch was first, at a filling station outside Addingham, seventeen years old, on his own, sitting on the roof of the shop with a bag of dry pasta and a claw hammer and a plan to stay there indefinitely, which he defended for twenty minutes and abandoned in four. He had been at school on the Thursday. He said everything twice from the beginning; Cowie thought at first it was fear, and it was not, it was simply how he was.

Feeley and the Ashrafs were together, in a farmhouse above Silsden that they had been in for a week and had not searched properly. Dermot Feeley was forty-six and had done regional sales for a flooring company and he was the most immediately likeable person Cowie had met in his adult life, and Cowie liked him within about ninety seconds, and would like him for a year and a half, and has still not got all the way to the other side of it. Wendy Ashraf was thirty-eight and had come out of Keighley with her daughter on the back of a bike. Nadia was seven. She had a cat carrier with no cat in it and would not be parted from it, and nobody ever asked, and

eventually she told Hutch, months later, and Hutch told nobody, which is the single best thing anybody did that year.

Erin Mowat they got last, and by accident, and she was the only one of them who did not want to be got.

She was a locum pharmacist and she had barricaded herself into the dispensary of a chemist's in Skipton with the shutter down, and she had been in there eleven days with the entire contents of a pharmacy and a sink, and when Sandhu knocked on the shutter and shouted that there were six of them and one was a child, Erin Mowat's first reply, through three inches of steel, was: "How do I know that?"

It took two hours. Sandhu did most of it. In the end what got the shutter up was not an argument, it was Nadia, who got bored of the adults and sat down on the pavement with her back to the shutter and started telling the empty cat carrier a very long story about a dog, and after about ten minutes of that the shutter went up eighteen inches.

Erin came out with a rucksack that weighed more than she did.

"Right," she said, looking at the seven of them, at Feeley's smile and Sandhu's hands and the hammer down the leg of Hutch's tracksuit, at Cowie, who she would later say looked like a man who had been sacked from somewhere. "Whose is the child?"

"Mine," said Wendy.

"Then I'm coming with you," said Erin Mowat, "and not because of the rest of you."

That was the eighteenth of April. There were seven of them, counting Nadia, and they had a bike, a hammer, a bread knife, a rucksack full of a pharmacy, and a leaflet with a map on it that showed no roads.

Sandhu got the map out and turned it round twice and said the sentence that decided the next fourteen months.

"Right," she said. "Up. Nobody's up."

SEVEN

HILLFOOT

Sandhu was right about up.

It took them six days to learn why, and the reason turned out to be nothing to do with height. It was that the dead went where the roads went. They were not clever and they did not navigate, but they walked, and a walking thing follows the surface that is easiest to walk on, and so they came down valleys and along carriageways and through the fenced runs between fields the way rain goes into a gutter. Get off the tarmac and up onto the tops, and after about four hundred feet the world simply emptied.

It was also, in April, on the Pennines, appallingly cold, and Nadia stopped speaking for two days, and Wendy came within about an hour of turning them all round.

They found Hillfoot on the sixth evening.

It was a farm on a slope above a beck, three-quarters of a mile up a lane that could be seen from the yard for its whole length, with a house and a parlour and two stone barns arranged round a yard by people who had been thinking about cattle, and a spring in the field above the buildings that came down through a pipe into a trough and had presumably been doing so since somebody's great-grandfather. There were fourteen sheep in the top field and a dog that would not come near them for a week and then would not leave.

The gate was shut. Feeley was the one who noticed what that meant, and said it out loud, and got it wrong.

"Somebody's here," he said. "Shut gate, that's somebody."

Sandhu went in first with the shotgun she had taken off a farm outside Bolton Abbey and had not yet fired. Cowie went second, because he had decided, in a way he did not examine, that he was going to be the person who went second from now on.

Nobody was there. Tom Shackleton was in the kitchen in a chair by a dead range with a blanket over his knees and a mug on the floor beside him, and he had been there about five weeks, and he had died of something quick and ordinary that had nothing to do with any of it. Erin looked at him for a while from the doorway and said, "That's a stroke, probably. Or his heart. He's not been ill long, look at the room."

The room was tidy. That was the thing. He had washed up.

They buried him in the orchard on the second morning, which took four hours because the ground up there is nine inches of soil on a bed of gritstone, and Hutch said the only words anybody said, which were "cheers, mate," twice.

And then they had a farm.

. . .

The rules were nailed to the door of the milking parlour, on a sheet of A4 in a plastic wallet, in a hand that sloped backwards. Seven of them.

They were not, Cowie thought when he first read them, rules about the dead. There was nothing about the dead on the sheet at all. They were:

Boil it.

Don't shout.

Two doors.

Cut a year ahead.

Nowt goes back in the seed shed.

Gate behind you every time.

Ask before you touch owt in the top barn.

Feeley read it and laughed and said the old boy had been getting himself organised, and it was months before any of them understood that four of the seven had been written before the Handover and had been about sheep, and that Tom Shackleton had gone out to that door at some point in the last fortnight of his life, on his own, with a pen, and added three.

Nobody could agree which three. They argued about it for a year. Sandhu said two doors was obviously new. Erin said two doors was about a milking parlour, and that *don't shout* was the new one, because you do not need to tell yourself not to shout on a farm you have lived on for fifty years. Hutch thought all seven were new. Hutch thought Tom Shackleton had written them the night before he died, as a message, which was not true and which nobody argued him out of.

They kept every one of them. That is the part Cowie thinks is worth putting down. Seven people who had never met the man, who had buried him in his own orchard with his own spade, ran their lives for fourteen months off a laminated sheet on a door, and it worked, and none of them ever seriously proposed taking it down.

. . .

The first fortnight was the happiest Cowie had been since he was about eleven.

He is aware of how that sounds. He has said it out loud exactly twice and both times it landed badly.

But the world had been taken away, and with it every single thing he had been quietly failing at: the shelf unit, the bike with the flat tyre, the Sunday lunches, the thirty-four years, the question of whether he was going to become the sort of man who has a wife. All of it, gone, in an afternoon, and what was left was a list of things that needed doing before dark, every one of which was concrete, and most of which he could do.

He was good at it, too, and that was the surprise. Not brave; he had established that in a launderette in Horsforth and did not expect to be surprised on that score again. But it turned out that a farm running seven

people on nothing is a supply chain problem, and Neil Cowie had spent nine years doing supply chain problems in a glass box named after a river.

He inventoried the house in a day and a half. He worked out that they had between them fifty-one days of calories at the rate they had been eating and a hundred and forty at a rate they would hate, and he built the rate they would hate, and Sandhu looked at the sheet of paper for a long time and then pinned it up next to Tom Shackleton's rules.

"Right," she said. "That's you, then."

"What's me?"

"That. That's your job." She was already going out to the yard. "You do the numbers, I'll do the arguing."

It was the first time in his life anyone had promoted him in under two minutes.

. . .

Roles came out of that fortnight and never really changed.

Sandhu decided. She had not asked for it and did not enjoy it, and she was the only candidate, and she knew all three of those things. She ran the day the way she had run a department: badly attended, endlessly negotiated, and somehow always in the end done.

Erin held the medicine, which meant Erin held every argument that had a body in it. She kept the rucksack in the top barn under a horse blanket and she was the only one who knew what was in it, and when Feeley suggested a joint inventory in the second week she said no, flatly, in front of everybody, and did not explain, and Sandhu backed her, and that was the first real crack in the house and nobody saw it for what it was.

Feeley did people. He could talk to anybody. In the second month, on a run down to a village, he got them four jerry cans and a working radio out of a man who had been holding him at the end of a garden fork nine minutes earlier, and he did it by asking after the man's back.

Wendy did the food and Nadia and, increasingly, everybody's morale, because she was the only one of them with an actual dependant and had

therefore made a decision very early on about what she was going to let herself feel.

Hutch did whatever was hardest and never once said so.

And Cowie did the numbers. Water in, water out, days of fuel, days of flour, when the sheep would lamb and what that was worth, how many candles they had against how many hours of dark there would be in November. He made a chart. Feeley called it the planogram and everybody used the word within a fortnight, and there is a version of Neil Cowie that would have minded about that, and by June that version was gone.

He was, on the ordinary Tuesdays of that first summer, a useful man in a working place.

He thought about his sister every day, usually at about seven in the evening, which was when the light went off the top field. He had a thing he did, which he told nobody about for a year: he would say, out loud but very quietly, wherever he was standing, "I'm going to tell that one at the caravan." And then he would carry on with whatever he was doing.

EIGHT

THE STOCK BOOK

The stock book was in the top barn, in a feed bin, under a bag of layers pellets, and Hutch found it in June while looking for something else.

It was a ledger from an agricultural supplier, ruled and dated, and Tom Shackleton had used it for eleven years for the thing it was for and then, at some point that nobody could pin down, had started using it for everything. Sowings. Weather. What the vet said. What a ewe had done in 2019 that had annoyed him. Four pages of somebody's phone numbers with three of them crossed out. And, from the March before the Handover, in a hand that got worse as it went, a set of notes about a lamb that had gone wrong, which stopped mid-sentence on the eleventh of April.

There were four years of yields in it.

Cowie sat with it for two days and came out of the barn a different person, and the thing he came out with was a calendar.

"Right," he said, in the kitchen, with everybody there because Sandhu had made everybody be there. "Bad news. Are we ready for the bad news?"

"Get on with it," said Sandhu.

"We're going to be hungry in June."

"It is June."

"Next June." He put the chart on the table. He had drawn it in pencil on the back of four sheets of Tom Shackleton's headed order forms, and it was, he says, the best piece of work he has ever done, better than the four-

way, better than anything in the two hundred and six pages. "Here's the store. Here's us eating it at the rate we hate. Here's when the potatoes come out, if we get them in this week and if the blight stays off. And here." He put his finger on a gap between two lines, about four inches wide, in the following year. "Here's the bit nobody plans for."

Feeley leaned over it. "That's summer."

"That's the hungry gap. That's the store gone and the harvest not in. Eight weeks. It happens in May and June when the whole place looks like it's dripping with food, and there's nothing in a hedge in May that'll feed a person." He tapped the ledger. "He's got it in here. Three years running. He's written *lean* across May and then in 2021 he's written *very lean, sold two*."

There was a silence.

"So what do we do," said Wendy.

"We eat less now than we need to. Starting today. So that there's something left in the box in fourteen months."

"How much less?"

Cowie told them how much less, and Nadia, who was seven and had been listening the way children listen, said, "Is that including me?" and the room went quiet in a way that Cowie has never forgotten, and Sandhu said, "No, love. Not including you."

They ran it that way for a year, and the arithmetic held, and there is no version of the events that follows in which the arithmetic is what killed them.

. . .

That summer is the one they all mean when they say *at Hillfoot*, and none of them, afterwards, could describe a single day of it.

That is the problem with the good bit. There is a great deal of it and it is all the same and it goes past like water. They put a hundredweight of potatoes in. They cut wood in July for the following winter, because it was on the door, and swore about it in July and did not swear about it in

January. They cleaned the spring pipe. They ate mutton four times and salted the rest and got the salting wrong the first time and lost a quarter of it, and Wendy cried about that for about ninety seconds and then never mentioned it again.

They got a routine for the lane, which was two people at the wall at the bend, and never fewer, and Sandhu enforced it like a woman who had spent twenty years getting fifteen-year-olds to remember their kit.

Nadia learned to read properly off Erin, out of a veterinary formulary and a Beano annual, which between them contain most of the English language.

Hutch grew two inches and put on a stone of muscle and became, without anybody discussing it, the person you sent up a ladder.

And they were, for about five months, safe, in the specific sense that they were more likely to be hurt by a gate than by anything else, and that is the version of safety the world had come down to, and it was enough.

. . . .

Erin did the inventory in August, on her own, in the top barn, and then came and found Cowie in the yard and told him, which was not nothing, and which he understood at the time was not nothing.

"I want one other person to know what's in the bag," she said. "In case I'm dead."

"Tell Sandhu."

"Sandhu will spend it." She sat down on the mounting block. "Sandhu will look at somebody in pain and she will spend it, because that is who she is and it's why she gets to be in charge. You'll look at a chart."

"That's a horrible thing to say about me."

"Yes," said Erin. "Sorry. It's also why I'm telling you."

Here is what was in the bag, and Cowie could recite it two years later.

Paracetamol, a large quantity, effectively unlimited. Ibuprofen, the same. Some codeine, perhaps forty tablets, which Erin had already decided was for one thing and one thing only. A salbutamol inhaler with about a

third in it, for a person they had not yet met. Antiseptic, dressings, tape, three bottles of saline. An unopened box of insulin she had taken out of a fridge on the second day and which had been useless for four months and which she had not been able to throw away.

And one full course of co-amoxiclav. Twenty-one tablets. Three a day for seven days.

"That's it?" said Cowie.

"That's it. There was more. There was a lot more, and it was in the pharmacy in Skipton, and I had eleven days in there on my own to bring out what I could carry, and I brought paracetamol." She was not looking at him. "Because I was frightened of being in pain, and I was not thinking about anybody else, because there was not anybody else yet."

"Erin, that's—"

"Don't." She stood up. "I'm not asking for the speech. I'm telling you the number so that two of us know it. Twenty-one tablets. One course. One person, one time, and after that we are back in about 1930."

She went in.

Cowie stood in the yard for a while with the dog. It was August and the light was still on the top field at eight and the sheep were making the noise they make, and he thought about a box on a shelf with twenty-one tablets in it, and about the fact that the number was small enough to be a single decision, which meant that one day it would be one, and that somebody would have to make it.

He did not put it on the chart. He did not know how to draw it.

THE LONG FIELD

It began, as these things do, with an entirely unromantic afternoon in which they nearly died in a shed.

They had gone down to Bracewell in September, the two of them, for a list: batteries, salt, anything with a lid. It was Cowie's fourth run and Erin's ninth. They had a bicycle and a wheelbarrow, which sounds ridiculous and was, and which was the best solution anybody had come up with to the problem of carrying forty kilos three miles uphill without an engine.

The shed was behind a house on the edge of the village and it had a lawnmower in it, and a chest freezer, and eleven of them.

They had come in through the front. That was the mistake and it was Cowie's, and it broke Tom Shackleton's rule about two doors, which he had recited to Hutch four days earlier in the yard like a man who understood things.

What Erin did was get the freezer over.

It went down across the doorway on its face with a noise like the end of the world, and it gave them the six inches of gap they needed at the top, and she went through it first and got hold of his collar and hauled, and something got his boot and he lost the boot, and then they were in a garden in the rain with the shed door bulging and a fence to get over, and they got over the fence and lay in a bramble patch for eleven minutes listening to the shed.

Then Erin started laughing and could not stop, and it went on rather too long and stopped rather too suddenly, and she lay on her back in the wet with her hands over her face and said, "I'm all right. I'm all right. Don't."

They walked back up with the wheelbarrow and got in at dusk with three tins and no batteries, and Cowie had one boot, and Hutch, who was on the wall at the bend, took one look and said, "Where's your boot. Where's your boot," and that was the whole debrief.

. . . .

She came out to the top barn that night while he was doing the water.

He did the water at ten because the tank reading was steadier when nobody had drawn on it for an hour, and it was a job that took four minutes and he made it take twenty because it was the only part of the day he had on his own.

"Are you going to tell Sandhu it was you?" she said, from the door.

"Yes."

"Good." She came in and sat on the feed bin. "I was going to tell her anyway, so that saves an argument."

"You'd have grassed me up."

"Instantly." She had a candle in a jam jar, which was the arrangement, and she put it on the floor between them so it would not be in a window. "I've been thinking about it all the way back. And it wasn't the going in the front that nearly did us. It was that I was thinking about the freezer. I saw that freezer when we came in and I thought *that could go over*, and then I thought about that instead of listening."

"That's what saved us."

"That's not the point." She rubbed her eyes with the heels of her hands. "The point is I've got about four thoughts at once now, all day, every day, and they're all like that. I look at a room and I see the exits and the weight of things and whether the floor's rotten, and I can't turn it off, and I have not had a single ordinary thought since the eighteenth of April."

Cowie put the dipstick back in the tank.

"I had one this morning," he said.

"Go on."

"I wondered whether Kerrigan approved the eleven centimetres."

Erin looked at him.

"There was a range review," he said. "Eleven centimetres of shelf, and a company in Ripon, and two blokes who'd have got a job out of it. And it went to a meeting in a room called Wharfe on the Tuesday after, and I've been wondering since about half four this morning whether he signed it off before the world ended."

"Neil, there is no shop."

"I know that."

"There's no shelf. There's no Ripon."

"I know there's no Ripon," said Cowie, "and I would still quite like to know."

And Erin Mowat put her head back against the stones of the top barn and laughed, properly, the way she had laughed in the bramble patch, only this time it stopped when she wanted it to.

. . .

Afterwards they sat on the barn floor with their backs against the bin and the candle between them, and neither of them went in, and both of them knew that both of them had noticed.

"I want to say something and I want to say it badly," she said, "so I'm going to say it fast. I'm thirty-four and I have been on my own for about six years, including before, and I had decided that was fine and I had a flat I liked and a job I was good at and I had genuinely stopped minding. And I have now spent five months in a house with seven people and I have never been less on my own or more lonely, and I am frightened all the time, and when that freezer went over I thought, right, this is it, and the thing I was sad about was not my mum or my flat or anything you'd put in a film."

"What was it?"

"It was that nobody had touched me since April."

The candle did the thing candles do.

"Not like that," she said. "Or, yes, like that, but that's not the—" She stopped. "Wendy does Nadia's hair. Every night, on the settle, twenty minutes. And I sit there and watch it and I could weep."

Cowie did not say anything clever, which he counts as the second good decision of his adult life.

He put his hand out palm up on the stone floor between them and left it there, and after a while she put hers into it, and they sat like that for a long time, not talking, with the dog scratching at something in the yard and the sheep doing what sheep do at night, and at some point she leaned in and put her forehead against the side of his head and stayed there.

They did not go any further than that for another eleven days.

When they did, it was in the same barn, and it was quiet, and hurried at first and then not, and afterwards she lay with her head on his arm and said, in a completely ordinary voice, "Right. Well. That's the first thing I've chosen since April."

That is the sentence. Everything that happens to those two people afterwards, all of it, the argument on the moor and the thing on the stairs at Draycott and the last morning, comes off that sentence, and Cowie did not understand it at the time and understood it entirely by the following spring.

. . .

Sandhu knew within four days, because Sandhu knew everything.

She said one thing about it, in the yard, holding a bucket, not stopping.

"Good," she said. "Don't let it make you stupid in a shed."

Feeley knew within a fortnight and was delighted, and made it his business, and got a bottle of something appalling out of the top barn and made a toast at supper that went on for a minute and a half and had two genuinely funny lines in it, and Nadia asked what a toast was, and Wendy

explained, and Erin went scarlet and Cowie sat there with his ears burning and the whole table laughing at him.

He has gone back to that supper more than to any other night of his life. Seven people at a table in a farmhouse kitchen in the autumn, with candles, eating stew that was mostly potato, laughing at him.

Two of them were dead within seven months, and by the following August there were four.

WHAT CAME UP THE LANE

It came up the lane on the ninth of October at about four in the afternoon, and it came because of a chimney.

They had been burning green wood for eleven days. The dry stack had run low at the wrong end of the season and there had been a discussion about it, and the discussion had gone the way discussions go in a cold house in October, and Sandhu had made the call to burn the green and cut more in November. It smoked. It sat over the farm on the still days in a white column you could see from the tops, and Cowie had put it on the chart in his own handwriting under a heading he had written as a joke, VISIBILITY, and had then stopped finding funny.

Hutch was on the wall at the bend and he did everything right.

He did not shout. That was the thing Sandhu said afterwards, over and over, to anyone who would listen and mostly to herself: the boy did not shout. He came up the lane at a walk, and got in the yard, and said, quietly, in his ordinary voice, twice, "There's a lot of them. There's a lot of them," and then went and got the ladder.

There were about sixty.

Sixty is not the thousand on the A65. Sixty is a number a farm can survive, and Hillfoot did survive it, and that is not what this chapter is about.

They did it the way they had rehearsed it in July when it had felt faintly embarrassing.

Everybody into the house. Both barns shut and barred, which was for the sheep and did not work. Nadia and Wendy upstairs in the back bedroom with the door wedged and the window rope on the sill, which was Erin's idea and which nobody had ever tested with a person on it. The rest of them at the two doors, which was the whole of Tom Shackleton's third rule and the reason they were still alive: two doors, watched by four people, in a building with a wall round three sides of the yard.

They held for two hours, and the two hours were mostly waiting, which nobody ever believes.

Then the wall by the midden went, because sixty of them leaning on a dry stone wall is more weight than a dry stone wall has ever been asked to carry, and after that it was in the yard and it was close work in the dark with the dog going mad in the parlour, and Sandhu shot four and then stopped shooting because of the noise and used the barrel instead.

Feeley was magnificent. That has to go in. Whatever comes later, on the ninth of October Dermot Feeley stood in the doorway of the kitchen for forty minutes with a spade and did not give an inch, and when Hutch went down under one at the corner of the parlour it was Feeley who went out into the yard for him, alone, and dragged him back in by the hood of his tracksuit.

By nine it was over. They lost eleven of the fourteen sheep, the whole of the far wall, four panes, and the dog's nerve, which never fully came back.

Nobody was bitten. Cowie wants that on the record, for reasons that will be obvious by chapter sixteen.

. . .

At about half past nine, with the yard full of what was in the yard, Erin went out to the orchard because that was where the water butt was and everybody needed to wash.

She came back in without the bucket.

"Neil," she said, from the door. "Come here a minute."

The orchard was forty yards up the slope behind the house, four apple trees and a damson that had never done anything, and Tom Shackleton was buried at the top end under the flattest bit of ground they had been able to find. They had put a stone on it. Not a headstone; a stone, a big flat one off the wall, because Hutch had wanted to and nobody had a better idea.

The stone was over.

The hole was open from the inside. That is a distinction that Cowie had never had cause to make in his life and made instantly, standing there with a lamp, because soil that has been dug from above goes in a pile and soil that has come up from beneath goes in a ring.

"He was in the ground five months," said Erin.

"I know."

"Neil, we buried him in May. In *May*. And he wasn't bitten, I looked at him, I looked at him properly because I thought that's what you do, and he had nothing on him, he had a stroke in a chair with a blanket on his knees."

"I know."

"Then how."

Cowie did not have an answer, and neither did she, and the two of them stood in an orchard in the dark next to an empty hole with the answer standing about nine feet away between the second and third apple trees, facing them, entirely still, in a cardigan.

. . .

Here is the part.

Cowie sent Erin down to the house. She did not want to go and he did not argue with her, he simply said, "Erin. Go down," in a voice he had not used before, and she looked at him for a second and went.

Then he put the lamp on the ground with the beam across the grass, and picked up the spade that was still stuck in the ground by the damson

from the burial in May, and walked round the outside of the orchard, along the wall, in the dark, until he was behind it.

It did not turn round. They do not, unless something happens.

He thought about a fire extinguisher on a wall by a till.

He thought about the eleven minutes on the floor of the launderette with his back against a machine, and about the sound the door had made when he had gone out through the yard full of pallets, and about the fact that in two years he had never once been able to finish the sentence he had started that night, which was *I am sorry, I am so*.

Then he did it, from behind, up at the top of the neck where his sister had shown him with two fingers, and it took him three goes, and it was the worst thing he had ever done and it took eleven seconds and afterwards he sat down on the wall and was sick.

Sandhu found him there twenty minutes later. She sat down on the wall next to him and did not put an arm round him, because she knew him by then, and after a while she said:

"That's not for Tom, that."

"No."

"No." She looked out over the black field. "Does it help?"

Cowie thought about it honestly, which took a while.

"No," he said. "But I can do it now."

"Aye," said Sandhu. "That's the bit nobody tells you. It's not that it gets easier. It's that you find out you're somebody who can."

They put the stone back the next morning and dug it deeper and put two stones on it, and Feeley said the obvious thing, which was that the old boy must have been bitten after all and they had missed it, and everybody agreed, because the alternative was not a thing that could be held in the head on the tenth of October with a wall down and eleven dead sheep.

Erin did not agree. She went quiet on it in a specific way that Cowie learned to recognise over the following months, which was not sulking. It was a woman putting something in a drawer to work on later.

ONE DOSE

Wendy Ashraf was bitten on the eighteenth of November, on the forearm, through a coat and a jumper, by one that came out from under a hedge on the Bracewell road.

It was not a bad bite. That was the whole difficulty, and it is why the four days that followed were the worst four days any of them had, worse than the night Hillfoot went, worse in some ways than Draycott. If it had been her throat there would have been nothing to discuss. It was two inches of broken skin on the meat of the left forearm, and it bled a normal amount, and she walked home.

She knew before anybody said anything. She got up into the yard and she put her bag down and she said, "Right. Nadia's not to come in the kitchen," and she said it in the voice of a woman who has thought about this exact afternoon for seven months.

. . .

Erin cleaned it out in the kitchen with the door shut, and irrigated it for twenty minutes with boiled water, which is longer than anyone can be bothered to do it and which she did with a clock going, and then dressed it and came out into the yard where the other five of them were standing in the cold not looking at each other.

"It's a wound," she said.

"Erin," said Feeley.

"No. Listen to me, because I'm the only one here who has any business with an opinion." She had her sleeves rolled and her forearms were wet to the elbow. "It is a *wound*. It is a dirty puncture wound on a forearm and it is going to go septic, because they all go septic, because a human mouth is the filthiest thing in the country. And I have twenty-one tablets in a bag in the top barn that are for precisely this."

Nobody said anything.

"That's what they're for," said Erin. "That is what they are actually for. That is the entire reason I carried that bag out of Skipton."

"And if it isn't the wound," said Feeley.

"Then the tablets don't matter either way and we've lost twenty-one tablets."

"And if it is the bite," said Feeley, "the thing that everybody in this country has understood since April, the thing we have all seen, the thing that *he* has seen"—and he did not point at Cowie, he did something worse, which was to not point at him—"then we've spent the only course we've got on a woman who is going to turn anyway, and the next person who puts a fork through their foot in that yard dies of it."

"You do not know that she is going to turn."

"Nobody knows anything," said Feeley. "That's my whole point, love. Nobody knows anything, and when nobody knows anything you don't spend the last of something."

. . .

Sandhu let it run for two hours, which was her method, and then took it into the kitchen with the five of them and Wendy sitting up at the table with her arm in a sling and a cup of tea she was not drinking.

"Wendy first," said Sandhu. "It's her arm."

Wendy Ashraf said this, and Cowie has never repeated it to anybody without stopping in the middle:

"I want the tablets," she said. "I want them and I'll say why. It isn't because I think it'll work." She was very calm. "It's four days. If I take them I get four days of not being the woman who's dying in the back bedroom, I get four days where I'm having treatment, and Nadia gets to watch her mum having treatment instead of watching everybody wait." She turned the mug round. "And if I'm wrong I've cost you twenty-one tablets, and I'm sorry, and you'll manage, because you managed before you had them."

Then she said, "But I'm not going to ask twice, and I want somebody else to decide, because she's seven and I'm not having her told, later, that her mum took the medicine."

And then, God help them all, she went upstairs.

Sandhu turned to Cowie.

"Numbers," she said.

He has been asked, since, why he did not refuse. He has been asked it once by Erin, in March, in the worst conversation of his life, and about four hundred times by himself.

The answer is that he did not know he was allowed to. He had been asked for the numbers in that kitchen fifty times over seven months, about flour and candles and firewood and the hungry gap, and every single time he had given them, and the giving of them was the thing that made him a person in that house rather than a man they had picked up on a road. Sandhu said numbers and Cowie's mouth opened.

"We've got one course," he said. "There's seven of us, six if. Winter's four months. On last winter's rate, and Tom's book, we'd expect between two and four wounds bad enough to want it, and that's not counting chests, and Nadia had a chest thing in September that Erin was worried about."

"That's not a decision," said Erin. "That's a chart."

"You asked me for the—"

"I didn't ask you for anything."

"Erin," said Sandhu.

"No, because he's about to do the thing," Erin's voice had not gone up. It had gone down, which was worse. "He's about to give you a number that is technically correct, and you are all going to hear a number and think that a decision has been made by mathematics, and it hasn't. There is a woman upstairs who has asked for the only thing she has asked for in seven months and we are going to say no to her with a spreadsheet."

The kitchen was quiet.

"Neil," said Erin. "Say it isn't the bite. Say it out loud. You're the one who stood in that orchard."

And Cowie, who had stood in that orchard with a spade in his hands eleven days after burying a man who had died of a stroke, and who had not been able to hold the thought since, said:

"I don't know what happened in the orchard."

Erin looked at him for about three seconds.

Then she got up and went out and the back door banged, and Sandhu said, into the silence, "Right," and that was the decision, and no one voted, and nobody in that kitchen ever afterwards described it as a decision that had been made by any particular person.

. . .

Wendy Ashraf died on the twenty-second of November at about three in the morning, of sepsis from an infected forearm, and it took four days, and it was not quick and it was not peaceful, and Erin sat with her for the last thirty hours and gave her all forty of the codeine tablets, which had been for one thing and one thing only, and which had been for exactly this.

Nadia was in the back bedroom with Hutch, who read the Beano annual to her, out loud, twice through, in the dark, doing the voices. He was eighteen by then. He did not stop when the noise started downstairs. He read louder and did the voices, and he has never once mentioned it since, and Cowie would put that night against anything anybody did at Hillfoot in fourteen months.

Cowie did the necessary thing at about four, in the kitchen, with the door shut, and did not need three goes.

They buried her in the orchard next to Tom Shackleton and put three stones on her, and Sandhu said what needed saying, and Nadia asked if her mum was going to come out like the man had, and every adult in that orchard said no, and every one of them was lying, and every one of them knew that every one of the others was lying, and Nadia was seven and knew it too.

Erin did not speak to Cowie for eleven days.

When she did, it was in the top barn, and all she said was: "Twenty-one tablets. They're still in the bag. Nobody's had them. I want you to know that they are still in the bag."

BRACEWELL

They went down to Bracewell in January because they had to, and because Cowie's chart said February, and Cowie's chart had been right about everything for nine months, which is a dangerous thing for a chart to be.

The village had a Co-op on the main street with a car park behind it and a delivery bay, and the reason nobody had emptied it in nine months was standing on the flat roof of the delivery bay with a rifle across her arms, and had been standing there in shifts, day and night, since the previous May.

There were fourteen of them. They had the shop, the pub next door, the two houses behind, and a chain-link fence they had taken off a builders' yard and put across both ends of the street, and they had a bell.

Sandhu walked up the middle of the road with her hands out from her sides and Feeley three paces behind her and the rest of them at the bend where they could not be seen and could not do anything, which was the arrangement, and which Cowie hated then and understands now.

They were there four hours.

. . .

Denny Hargreaves had run the pub. He was about fifty-five, and he had a way of leaning that was pure bar, and he came out to the fence and put his forearms on the top rail of it and said, "Well then," as though they had come in at half eleven on a Tuesday.

He was not a bad man. Cowie wants that established at the top, because of what happened in March, and because the easy version of this is a village of thugs and it was not that, it was fourteen frightened people who had done, on the whole, rather better than Hillfoot had.

"You've got a shop," said Sandhu.

"We have."

"We've got mutton, salt, spuds and about forty pound of oats."

Denny Hargreaves looked at her for a while.

"Go on then," he said.

It took four hours because everything took four hours. The rate was the hard part: what is a leg of mutton against a case of tinned tomatoes, in January, in a world with no money, when both parties have to do this again in six weeks and neither can afford to be the one who was mugged. Feeley did it. That is what Feeley was for, and watching him do it was, Cowie thought at the time, like watching Sandhu handle a gate: the same economy, the same total absence of visible effort.

He got them nine cases, four hundred batteries, two gas bottles, a box of candles the size of a suitcase, and a laying hen, for four sheep and the promise of seed potatoes in the spring. He got the hen thrown in at the end, for nothing, by asking after Denny's knee.

And at about half three, with the deal done and both sides in that loose and slightly giddy state that follows a long negotiation, Feeley said, easily, as though it had only that second occurred to him:

"You'll have got the chemist's, I suppose."

The temperature of the street changed.

"We have," said Denny.

"Anything in it?"

"Some."

"Antibiotics?"

Denny Hargreaves straightened up off the rail, and the woman on the roof of the delivery bay, who had not moved in four hours, moved.

"No," said Denny.

"I'm only asking."

"I know what you're asking, and the answer's no, and I'll tell you why so there's no bad feeling." He said it flatly and reasonably and it was the most frightening thing said all day. "We've got a lad of eleven in that pub with a chest on him like a squeezebox and we've got a woman expecting in March. That cupboard is not stock. That cupboard is not for trade. If you come here in six weeks with a hundred sheep I'll take the sheep and you'll not get one tablet, and if you come here for it any other road I'll shoot you off the wall and I'll not lose an hour's sleep. Now." He leaned back on the rail and the whole thing went out of his voice as fast as it had come. "Are you stopping for a brew, or what?"

They stopped for a brew.

. . . .

The walk back up was three miles with a barrow and a hen, and everybody was in a very good mood, and Cowie remembers it as one of the last uncomplicated evenings.

Hutch carried the hen inside his coat for the last mile because it had gone quiet and he was worried about it, and it came out at the top furious and entirely well, and Nadia named it Wendy within about four seconds, before any adult could get in front of it, and then looked round at all of them, at eight years old, with a face like a locked door, daring anybody.

"Wendy it is," said Sandhu.

. . . .

The argument happened that night and it was short.

"He's got a cupboard," said Feeley.

"He's got a cupboard," Sandhu agreed, "and he's got a lad with asthma and a woman due in March, and if we had it, we'd say the same. Word for word. We *did* say the same, in that kitchen, in November."

"That's my point."

"No it isn't."

"It is my point," said Feeley, and he was not shouting; Feeley never shouted, it was one of the things about him. "We sat in that kitchen and we said no to Wendy because we had one course. One. And if we'd had four, or six, we'd have given her three of them and she'd be sat there now." He pointed at the settle, at nobody. "And I'm not having it happen twice. That's all. I am not going to sit at that table a second time and hear Neil read a number out."

"Dermot," said Erin, "I want it too. I want it more than you do. And there's a lad in that pub who needs it more than either of us."

"There's a girl on that settle."

"There's a *lad in that pub*."

That was the shape of it, for about forty minutes, and at the end of it Sandhu said no, and said it in the way that closed a subject at Hillfoot, and Feeley said, "Right you are," and smiled, and got up and put the kettle on the range, and asked Hutch about the hen.

Cowie has gone over that evening more carefully than any other evening in his life, looking for the moment, and there is no moment. Feeley said right you are and put the kettle on, and the kettle was the end of it, and eleven weeks later they lost the farm.

THIRTEEN

WHAT FEELEY TOOK

Cowie found it on the eleventh of March, in a coat, looking for a pencil.

That is the entire mechanism. There was no suspicion and no detective work. He wanted a pencil to do the March count and the pencils lived in a jar on the dresser and there were none in the jar, and Feeley's coat was on the back of the kitchen door and Feeley kept a carpenter's pencil in it, and Cowie put his hand in the pocket and came out with a box.

Amoxicillin, 500mg, twenty-one capsules, the label torn off but the pharmacy's own printed sleeve still round it and a Skipton address on the sleeve.

There was a second box behind it, opened, with about half gone.

. . . .

He stood in the kitchen for a long time.

The clean thing, the thing he has been told by two separate people he should have done, was to walk out into the yard and go and find Sandhu.

What he actually did was put the boxes back in the coat and go and do the March count, and he did the March count correctly, all of it, flour and oats and salt and candles and the seed store and the two gas bottles, in the top barn, on his own, for two hours, in handwriting that he can still look at and see nothing wrong with.

Then he went and found Feeley in the woodshed.

"How long."

Feeley did not put the axe down and did not look up, and there was a moment, perhaps a second and a half, when Cowie understood that Dermot Feeley had been waiting eleven weeks for somebody to come into the woodshed and ask him that, and that some part of him was relieved.

"January," he said.

"When we were there? On the day?"

"When you were all stood having a brew." He split one, and set another up. "Back door of the chemist's is on the ginnel and the ginnel's not inside their fence. It took eleven minutes."

"Dermot."

"I know."

"There's a lad in that pub—"

"There's about four hundred tablets in that cupboard," said Feeley, "and I took forty-two, and I've used half of one course on Nadia's chest in February, which Erin will tell you she was going to lose her, and I'd do it again tonight." He set the axe head on the block and leaned on the handle and looked at Cowie for the first time. "Do you know what I did before? Twenty-two years in flooring. I never once did a thing I'd be ashamed to tell my mother. Not once, and that's not a boast, it's just how it went, because nothing ever asked me." He was very calm. "And then it asked me, and I sat at that table in November and I did the right thing, Neil, I did the sensible careful right thing with everybody else, and I have watched that little girl every single day since."

"That's not why you did it."

"No," said Feeley. "I did it because I couldn't stand it. That's the truth and it's worse."

. . .

There is a version of this in which Cowie handles it well, and it is not complicated, and he can produce it on demand at four in the morning: he takes Feeley to Sandhu that evening, they put the forty-two tablets minus

what has gone into a bag, and two of them walk down to Bracewell in daylight with their hands out from their sides and give Denny Hargreaves his medicine back and let him do whatever he is going to do about it. Denny would have taken the sheep. Denny would have called them every name he had and taken the sheep and the seed potatoes and probably the hen, and it would have been over, and there would have been a fence and a bell and a village three miles down the hill for the whole of the following year.

What Cowie did instead was ask for four days.

He is not sure, even now, what the four days were for. He told himself they were for deciding. He told Erin, later, that they were for deciding. Sandhu, who is the only person who has ever said the true thing about it, said this: that he had spent nine months as the man who produced the number, and that a man who produces the number is not the man who carries the decision, and that when the decision arrived in his hands in a woodshed in March he had done what he did in the kitchen at 47, which was to go inside and pack a bag.

On the second of the four days Erin found out, because Cowie told her, because he could not not tell her.

She sat down on the feed bin.

"Where," she said.

"His coat."

"How many."

"Forty-two. Half a course gone into Nadia in February."

Erin Mowat put both hands flat on the top of the bin and looked at the floor of the top barn for about a minute and a half.

Then she said, "So there was medicine three miles away in November."

"Erin."

"There was a cupboard with four hundred tablets in it three miles down that hill on the eighteenth of November and none of us knew, and Wendy Ashraf died of a wound in her arm." She was not crying. That was the thing. "And in January we all stood in the street and had a brew with the man who owns it."

"He'd not have given them."

"No," said Erin. "He'd not. And that's why it's not his fault, and it isn't Feeley's either, it's just where the tablets happened to be, and I am so tired, Neil. I am so tired of everything being nobody's fault."

. . . .

On the fourth day, before Cowie had said anything to anyone, the Bracewell people came up the lane.

They came at four in the afternoon in daylight with their hands out from their sides, which Cowie understood at the time and has never stopped being grateful for. Six of them, Denny in front, no rifle showing.

They had worked it out in January. Denny had known within about a day, because Denny Hargreaves counted his own cupboard weekly, and he had spent eleven weeks not being sure which of the six of them had done it, and had come up the hill in the end because his lad's chest was bad again and he had done the arithmetic on what was left.

Feeley did not let it get to a conversation. He came out of the woodshed with the bag already in his hand, forty-one boxes and the rest of the loose, and he walked down the yard and gave it to Denny Hargreaves and said, "It was me, on my own, they've none of them known till Tuesday," which was seventy per cent true and was the last generous thing he ever did.

Denny looked in the bag. He counted it, there, in the yard, taking his time, and nobody moved.

Then he handed the bag to the woman behind him and he looked up at the six of them by the kitchen door, at Sandhu, at Nadia holding a hen, and he said:

"Right."

That was all. They turned round and went back down the lane, and Sandhu let out a breath, and Hutch said, twice, "That's that, then. That's that, then," and everybody went in and had their tea.

Nine days later the fence at the bottom of the lane was opened, at night, from the outside, and every gate between Bracewell and Hillfoot was

opened with it, all the way up the valley, in order, by somebody who knew exactly which gates there were.

THE NIGHT HILLFOOT WENT

The gates were the cleverest thing anybody did in two years, and Cowie has never been able to work out whether Denny Hargreaves thought of it or whether it was the woman off the delivery bay roof.

You do not need to attack a farm. A farm is stone and it is above you and there are six of them and one of you. What you do is walk up the valley in the dark opening gates, every gate, in order, from the road to the tops, so that a thing which has come off the A65 at Gargrave and has spent nine months bumping along the same field boundaries has, for the first time since April, an unobstructed run of three miles uphill.

They did not have to bring anything. They only had to stop stopping it.

It took four days to arrive, which is the other thing about it. There was no assault. There was a Tuesday, and then a Wednesday on which Hutch counted eleven in the bottom field where there were normally none, and a Thursday on which Sandhu went down the lane to the second bend and came back up at a run for the first time in fourteen months, and a Friday.

By Friday teatime there were three hundred in the lane.

. . .

Cowie's chart had a page for this. It was headed EVAC and it had been written in July in a good mood, and it was, he discovered at about six o'clock on the twentieth of March, a work of complete fiction.

It assumed daylight. It assumed the lane. It assumed that seven people would each carry the load listed against their name, and the loads had been weighed, and the weighing had been done in a yard in the sun by people who were not at that moment listening to a noise.

What actually happened was this.

Sandhu got everybody into the top barn, because the top barn was stone and had the small high window that came out onto the bank behind, and the bank behind came out onto the fell. That was the second door. That was the whole of Tom Shackleton's third rule and it is the reason six people are alive.

Erin went for the drug bag, which was in the top barn, and got it.

Wendy the hen was in the parlour and nobody went for the hen.

Hutch went back for Nadia's cat carrier. Nobody sent him. He was gone for four minutes and came back through the window with it and with a cut on his forearm that Erin dressed on the fell in the dark, and he did not say anything about it either then or afterwards, and when Sandhu tore into him for it, properly, viciously, shaking, on the bank, he stood and took all of it and said, twice, "It's the only thing she's got. It's the only thing she's got."

The dog would not come. They called it for as long as they could and then longer than they should have, and Feeley went back down the length of the barn twice for it, and it was under the parlour steps and it would not come out, because it had never got its nerve back after October, and in the end Sandhu took hold of Feeley's collar with both hands and put him at the window.

And the seed store was in the low barn, forty feet across an open yard, and Cowie stood at the top window with his own chart in his head, the page that said SEED, PRIORITY ONE, and looked at forty feet of yard with eleven of them already in it, and made the correct decision, which was to leave a year of food in a stone shed and climb out of a window.

They lay on the bank above the farm for about twenty minutes because Nadia could not be made to move.

That is where they were when the range went. Somebody had banked it up at five o'clock out of pure habit, on a normal Friday, and at some point in the night it did what a banked fire does in a building with a door open and forty-eight hours of nobody in it, and the six of them watched the house they had lived in for fourteen months take, from a bank two hundred yards up the fell, in silence, with the noise of the lane underneath it.

Sandhu said one thing.

"Right," she said. "Well, they'll not get owt out of it either."

. . . .

They went over the top in the dark with what they had, which was:

The drug bag, less the codeine, which had gone into Wendy Ashraf in November.

Nine days of food, because Cowie had been keeping the go-bags stocked to a rota since July, which is the single reason anybody survived April, and which is the only thing from his entire chart that worked.

One shotgun and eleven cartridges. Two knives, an axe, Hutch's hammer.

Four coats between six people, because two of them had been on the back of the kitchen door, and one of those two had a carpenter's pencil in the pocket and nothing else in it any more.

An empty cat carrier.

And the leaflet, in Cowie's inside pocket, that had come down in a spill over four fields on the seventh day and said that the Handover was in its final phase.

They walked all night because there was nowhere to stop, and at about five in the morning they got into a barn on the Malham road and Erin dressed Hutch's arm properly by the light of the last of the batteries from Bracewell.

Nobody had been bitten. That is a sentence Cowie has written four times now and it will matter twice more.

Nadia sat with the carrier on her knees with the door of it open, facing out, all night, the way you do if you are eight and you have decided that something might still come.

F I F T E E N

WALKING WEATHER

There is nothing in the second half of March, and that is what it does to you.

Cowie had thought, in the way that a person who has read about hardship thinks about hardship, that the road would be a series of events. It was not. The road was eleven days of walking through cold rain in the Craven district with everything they owned on their backs, and in eleven days the total number of things that happened was four, and one of those was that the axe head came off.

What the road actually consists of is arithmetic and weather.

They did about nine miles a day for the first three days and then five, and then, after the business at the ford, three. They were wet from the second morning and they were never dry again. They ate cold because a fire was two hours of work and a signal, and by the fifth day Cowie was doing the calorie count in his head as he walked and knowing that the answer was wrong and doing it again in case it came out differently.

Sleep was the thing that took them apart. Two on watch, four down, in a barn or a caravan or, twice, in a hedge, and nobody got more than four hours in a row for a fortnight, and after about nine days of that the group stopped being a group in any sense Cowie would have recognised at Hillfoot. Sandhu snapped at Nadia on the eighth day. Actually snapped, at a child, about a bootlace, and then had to go and stand behind a wall for a while.

Hutch stopped saying things twice. That was how they measured it in the end, and it frightened all of them more than the rain did: the boy went quiet in the ordinary way, and said things once, like anybody, and the loss of that stupid harmless doubled sentence was, Erin said afterwards, the first funeral any of them had properly attended.

. . . .

Nobody spoke to Feeley.

It was not agreed. There was no discussion, and Sandhu, to her credit, tried twice to break it, and both times it closed over again within an hour. He carried more than anybody. He took the worst watch every night without being asked, which was the one from three, and he was the one who went into the buildings first from the fourth day onward, and everybody let him, and that was the punishment: not exclusion, exactly, but a sort of permanent grateful distance.

On the sixth night Cowie came off watch and Feeley was sitting in the doorway of the barn with his back to the frame.

"Ask us, then," said Feeley.

"Ask you what."

"Whatever it is you've been not asking us for a week."

Cowie sat down. He was too tired for a conversation and had it anyway.

"Was it worth it," he said. "Nadia's chest. In February."

Feeley thought about it properly, which was one of the things about him, and which made him so much harder to hate than anyone wanted him to be.

"That's not the question," he said at last. "The question is whether I'd have taken them if she'd been well. And I would. That's the bit I've had eleven days to think about. I didn't take them for the bairn, I took them because of November, and the bairn is what I've been using to keep myself off the hook, and if it hadn't been her chest in February it'd have been somebody's foot in June and I'd have been just as pleased with myself."

He looked out at the rain.

"Don't tell Erin that," he said. "I've not got another one in me."

Cowie and Erin had their argument on the moor above Airton, on the ninth day, in a horizontal wind, and it was not about Wendy, because they were not yet able to have that one. It was about the map.

He wanted to go north to Malham because there was a field centre marked on the leaflet map, one of the four dots, and because a field centre meant a building with a generator and a radio. She wanted to go west because west was away from the dots, and the dots were where everybody had walked in April, and everybody who had walked in April was still walking.

They stood on a hill in the rain and had thirty seconds of the ugliest conversation of their relationship, and at the end of it Erin said:

"You want it to be the field centre because it's on a chart."

"It's a *building* with a *generator*."

"You want there to be an answer somewhere with a roof on it," she said, "and you have wanted that since November, and you are going to keep walking towards buildings until one of them has something in it that makes what we did all right."

Then she put her hood up and walked, and he stood there in the wind for a bit and then followed her, because they were going north anyway; Sandhu had already decided.

That night Erin came and put her back against his in the corner of a caravan without saying anything, which was the apology, and he reached round and got hold of her hand, which was his, and in the morning neither of them mentioned it.

That is where they were on the twenty-ninth of March: six people, four coats, a hen's name on a girl's lips twice a day, an empty cat carrier, and a field centre at Malham Tarn where a man called Kerrigan, who had once had the power to approve or refuse eleven centimetres of shelf, was in fact

at that moment eleven miles away and dying in a car park, which nobody would ever find out.

SIXTEEN

MALHAM TARN

The field centre was a big Victorian house on the north shore of the tarn with a modern block on the back, and it had been requisitioned on the fifth day of the Handover by an organisation whose name appeared on the paperwork in three different forms, none of which any of them had heard of.

There were four vehicles in the yard with government plates and a generator the size of a transit container that had run out of diesel at some point in the previous summer. There were nine bodies in the modern block and they had been dead a long time and they had all died in the same room, which took them a while to understand and which they did not talk about afterwards.

And in what had been the library there was a table, and on the table there were three ring binders and a lab book, and the lab book had been kept by hand, in biro, by a woman who signed the bottom of each day's entry with the initials H.K.

They were in that house nine days. It is the only place in the whole two years that Cowie has ever wanted to go back to.

. . .

Erin read the lab book. It took her four days, because a third of it was chemistry she did not have and half the rest was abbreviation, and because she went back to the beginning twice.

Here is what H.K. had established between the eleventh of April and the second of August, in a requisitioned field centre with a generator and nine colleagues, in handwriting that got smaller as it went along.

That every sample they tested was positive. Every one. Not most: all. They tested one hundred and forty-one people in the first fortnight, including all of themselves, and then they tested a further two hundred and six, and they went out to a village in the second week of May and tested everybody in it, and there was not a single negative result in the whole of the north of England.

That it was in tissue banks. This is the entry Erin read out loud, twice, standing up. On the ninth of June H.K. had got into a hospital in Lancaster and pulled frozen tissue samples taken from surgical patients in a normal year, and every sample was positive, and the oldest one she could get her hands on was from the previous September, which was seven months before anybody had seen anything.

That it did nothing. In the living, in any quantity, in any tissue, it did nothing at all. It did not make people ill. It had no symptoms. It was, in H.K.'s handwriting, on the twelfth of June, *commensal, apparently inert, distribution effectively universal, and I cannot make it do anything to a living cell.*

And then the entry for the fourteenth of June, which is four lines long.

Trigger is cessation. Not vector. There is no vector. There is nothing to catch and there never was. Everyone is carrying it and has been for at least a year and it does nothing whatever until the host dies, and then it does that, and it does not matter how the host died.

Underneath that, in a different pen, on a different day:

Told L. He asked what about bites. Bites kill people. That is all bites have ever done.

. . .

They sat in the library of the field centre with the lab book on the table and the light going and nobody said anything for a very long time.

Sandhu got there first, because Sandhu always got there first, and she got there by going straight to the practical, which was her way of not going anywhere else.

"So it's not catching," she said.

"It was never catching."

"So a bite's a bite."

"A bite is a dirty puncture wound," said Erin, "and what kills you is what has always killed you, which is losing enough blood or getting an infection you can't fight. And then you get up, because everybody gets up. And you'd get up if you'd fallen off a ladder."

"Or had a stroke in a chair," said Cowie.

"Or had a stroke in a chair."

Hutch said, "So the old fella in the orchard—"

"Yes."

"—and Mrs Ashraf—"

"Yes," said Erin.

And Feeley, who had been standing at the window with his back to the room for about twenty minutes, said, without turning round:

"So they'd have worked."

Nobody answered him.

"The tablets," said Feeley. "In November. Twenty-one tablets and a dirty cut on a forearm. That's what they're for. That's what they are *actually* for, she said it, she stood in that yard and said it, that's the exact phrase she used." He was speaking very quietly and with tremendous care, the way a man does when he has understood that if he speeds up he will not be able to stop. "So we'd have given her the tablets and the arm would have cleared up and she'd have been sat at that table at Christmas."

"Dermot," said Sandhu.

"And I went and took forty-two off a lad with asthma in February," said Feeley, "because I couldn't stand November. And I was *right*. That's the—" and here he did stop, and put the heel of his hand against the window

frame, and stood there. "I was right and I was three months late and it cost us the farm."

. . .

They stayed nine days because of the food, and because there was a stove, and because for four of those days Nadia had a temperature and Erin would not move her.

Cowie spent most of it on the binders, which were not science. The binders were administration, and administration was the thing Cowie could read the way Erin could read a formulary.

He found the reason nobody had ever been told.

There is a document in the second binder dated the twenty-second of June, addressed to a regional office and copied to four people, in which H.K. sets out the finding in eleven lines and requests urgent guidance on public communication. There is a reply, dated the twenty-ninth, which is one paragraph long. The paragraph thanks her for the work. It notes that the finding is preliminary. It observes that current public guidance on avoidance and on the handling of the deceased is, in operational terms, unaffected, since both remain necessary regardless of mechanism. And it directs that the finding is not to be included in any regional briefing pending further review.

Cowie read that paragraph about thirty times.

He knew exactly what it was. He had written things like it. Not that, not with those stakes, but the same object: a paragraph whose job is to be defensible later, produced by somebody who is not lying and is not going to help, in a week when they have nine other things on. He could see the meeting. He could see the room and the screen that took eleven minutes to find a laptop.

Somewhere in a building with the power still on, an ordinary person with too much on had decided that this could wait until the review.

And so nobody was told, and so seven people sat round a kitchen table at Hillfoot in November and had an argument about whether a bite was a

death sentence, and every one of them was wrong, and the answer had been in a ring binder in a house forty miles away for five months.

. . .

Erin took the lab book. She carried it for the rest of it, and she has it now.

On the last night at the tarn she and Cowie sat outside on the steps with a blanket, and it was the first clear night since Hillfoot, and she said:

"I want to say the thing, and then I want to not have said it."

"All right."

"I'm glad we know." She had the book on her knees. "I've wanted to know since October, since that hole in the orchard, and now I know, and I want to say that it is better to know, because that is what I have always believed about everything." She looked out at the water. "And it isn't. It hasn't made one single thing better. It's just made November into something else."

"Into what?"

Erin Mowat thought about it for a long time.

"I don't know yet," she said. "That's the bit I'm frightened of."

SEVENTEEN

FEELEY

He announced it on the last morning at the tarn, in the yard, with his bag already packed, which was how you knew it was not a proposal.

"I'm going back to Bracewell."

"You're not," said Sandhu.

"They've got a cupboard and a lad with asthma and Kath had that baby in March." He was very reasonable about it. "And they think a bite's a death sentence, same as we did, because everybody thinks that, because the only people who ever found out different are nine dead scientists and us. So the first time one of them gets nipped on the arm they'll do exactly what we did, and they've got four hundred tablets on a shelf, and they'll not use them."

"Dermot, they'll shoot you off the wall. He said so. He said the words."

"He said that about the cupboard."

"He said that about you."

"Aye, well," said Feeley, and picked his bag up.

It went on for an hour. Sandhu used everything she had, including, at the end, Nadia, which she apologised for that night and which Feeley forgave instantly and which she has never forgiven herself for. Erin offered to go with him and he would not have it. Cowie said almost nothing, because Cowie had understood within about two minutes that this was not a plan, it was a payment, and that a man who has decided to pay cannot be argued out of it by people who are the ones being paid.

At four in the afternoon Sandhu said: "First light. You go at first light, with Neil and Hutch as far as the Airton road, and that is not a negotiation."

And Feeley said, "Right you are."

He went at eleven that night, on his own, out of the boot room window, which was the second door.

. . . .

They found him at twenty past seven the next morning, two and a half miles down, on the road below Kirkby Malham, in a gateway.

He had done everything wrong and he had done it knowingly, which is the part Cowie cannot get round. He had travelled at night, which they had not done since October. He had gone alone. He had taken the road rather than the wall line because the road is quicker, and he had been going quickly because he had three days of walking in front of him and he wanted to be through the low ground by dawn.

There had been perhaps five of them. It was hard to tell afterwards.

He was sitting up against the gatepost with his legs out in front of him on the tarmac and his bag still on one shoulder, and there was a great deal of blood, and it had come from high on the inside of his thigh, and Cowie stopped ten feet away and knew the shape of it on the road because he had knelt on a launderette floor for four hours and forty minutes with a mop handle in his hands.

"Now then," said Feeley.

Hutch made a noise and Feeley said, "Don't, lad," and Hutch stopped.

Cowie knelt down.

"Don't get the belt out," said Feeley. "I've had an hour to look at it. It's gone off twice already and I've had it in my hand." He moved his fingers slightly and Cowie saw that he did have it in his hand, his own belt, wet through, and that he had at some point buckled it round and at some point let it go. "I want you to sit down. I've got about ten minutes of

talking in us and I've been saving it up all night, and you'll not believe how much better I feel."

So they sat down in the road, one on each side of him, with the gate at their backs and the light coming up over Kirkby Fell.

. . . .

"Bracewell," said Feeley.

"We'll go."

"You'll go today. Not next week. Today, from here, the pair of you, and you'll not go back up for a vote, because Sandhu'll say no and she'll be right and I'll have done all this for nowt."

"We'll go today."

"Say what you're going to say to him."

Cowie said it. Feeley made him say it twice, and corrected him the second time, because Cowie had led with the science and Feeley said no, you lead with the lad's chest, you lead with the thing the man is frightened of at four in the morning, and then you tell him the science, and then you show him the book, and then, this is the bit, then you shut up and let him ask you a question, because a man who asks you a question has already started believing you.

Twenty-two years in flooring.

"Right," said Feeley. "Second thing." He had gone the colour Emeka Ogunremi had gone. "You'll not tell Nadia what I did in January."

"Dermot—"

"I'm not asking for a clean sheet. Tell her when she's twenty, tell her the lot, I don't care, I'll be a name by then." He swallowed. "But she's eight, and I'm the one that made her laugh, and there isn't going to be anybody else doing that for a bit, and if you take that off her this week to make yourself feel honest I will come out of the ground for you."

Cowie was crying by then, which he had not done since the eighteenth of April, and Feeley looked at him with enormous satisfaction and said, "There he is."

Then he said, "Third thing."

"Yes."

"You know the third thing."

"Yes."

"Because I'll not be long, and I don't want the lad doing it, and I'd rather it was somebody who's had the practice." He got hold of Cowie's sleeve, and his grip was not much. "And I want you to know it's a favour, Neil. It's not a thing you're doing to us. It's the last favour I'll ever ask anybody, and if you make a face about it afterwards I'll be very disappointed."

He talked for about six more minutes. Most of it was instructions and one bit of it was a story about a man in Warrington and a carpet, which was extremely funny, and which Hutch has told perhaps a hundred times since and which is the only version of Dermot Feeley that Nadia has.

Then he stopped being able to, and after a while he stopped.

Cowie did it from behind, up at the top of the neck, and did not need three goes, and did not make a face about it afterwards.

. . .

They put him in the gateway under a wall because the ground was nine inches on gritstone there as well, and Hutch built it up properly, which took an hour and a half, and would not let Cowie help.

Then the two of them turned round and walked south, away from the tarn, away from the others, twelve miles, and got to the chain-link fence at Bracewell at about six in the evening with their hands out from their sides.

Denny Hargreaves came out to the rail and put his forearms on the top of it and said, "You've a nerve."

Cowie led with the lad's chest.

He talked for eleven minutes, the way he had talked at a whiteboard in a glass box named after a river, and Denny Hargreaves listened to all of it with his face doing nothing whatever, and at the end Cowie stopped

talking and stood there and let the silence sit, because a man had told him to that morning while he was dying.

Denny looked at the lab book in Cowie's hands.

Then he said: "Where's Feeley?"

"Two mile below Kirkby Malham, under a wall. He set off at eleven last night to come and tell you this himself. He got about two and a half miles."

The gate at Bracewell was open before he had finished the sentence.

WHAT WE DID TO WENDY

It came in the third week of April, at a place called Halton Gill, in a bunkhouse with eleven bunks and five people in it, and it came because Cowie made a joke.

That is what he cannot get over. Not a row about the route, not the drug bag, not November. He made a joke, at supper, a small one, about the state of Hutch's cooking, and everybody laughed, and Erin laughed too, and then about four seconds after she had laughed she put her spoon down and went outside.

He found her round the side of the bunkhouse with her back against the stone.

"I can't," she said.

"Can't what?"

"That." She gestured at the door, at the light in it, at the laughing. "Sit there and be a person with you."

. . .

Cowie has reconstructed the conversation that followed a great many times and he is confident of it, because it is the only conversation of his life he has ever tried to hold onto word for word, and he has been rehearsing it since the twenty-second of April, and rehearsal does not make it any better.

"Is this November," he said.

"Yes."

"Then say it. Erin. You've been not saying it for five months and I would honestly rather—"

"You gave her the number."

"I gave her the number because she asked me for the number, and it was the correct number, and I have gone through it, and it is still the correct number." He heard his own voice going up and could not get it down. "One course. Four months of winter. Two to four wounds. That was true. It was true then and it's true now and if you can find a mistake in it I will —"

"There's no mistake in it."

"Then what—"

"That's not what I can't forgive you for," said Erin.

She said it quite gently, which is the reason it took his legs out.

"Neil, I have never once thought the number was wrong. That is not the thing." She was looking at the wall opposite. "The thing is that I asked you, in that kitchen, in front of everybody, to say what you saw in the orchard. And you said, *I don't know what happened in the orchard.*"

"I didn't know."

"You knew that a man who had died of a stroke in a chair in May came out of the ground in October," said Erin, "and so did I, and we stood in the dark and looked at the hole together, and we were the only two people at Hillfoot who had seen it, and I could not make that argument on my own because I am the one who wants the tablets used and everybody knows it. I needed one other person in that room to stand up and say *there is something wrong with what we all believe about bites*. Not to prove it. To make it a question." Her voice had not risen at all. "And you had it in your hands, and you put it down, because if you'd picked it up you'd have been responsible for what happened next."

Cowie stood in the dark and did not say anything, because there was nothing to say, because she was right, and had been right for five months, and had waited until Feeley was under a wall before she said it.

"I know what you're going to say," she said. "That it wouldn't have changed it. That Sandhu had already made her mind up and Feeley had the whole room and I'd have lost anyway."

"It's true."

"I know it's true! That's not—" and there it was, the only time her voice went, one crack in the middle of it, and then she got it back. "Neil, I would have lost that argument two-nil instead of losing it alone. Do you understand what that is worth? I have spent five months being the woman who wanted to waste the medicine on a dead woman, and I could have been one of two people who wanted to ask a question."

. . .

He said the wrong thing then. He knew it was the wrong thing while he was saying it and he said it anyway, because he had been standing against a wall for four minutes and something in him wanted to be hit.

"So what do you want me to do about it now?"

Erin Mowat looked at him for a long moment.

"Nothing," she said. "There's nothing to do about it. That's what I've been trying to tell you since Malham and you keep hearing a request." She pushed off the wall. "I'm not leaving. I'm not going to stop sleeping next to you, because it's April and there's no heating and I would rather be warm, and because I love you, which I want on the record as a complaint. I'm telling you that there is a thing between us now and it is not going to be talked about any more, and I would like you to stop trying to get it out of the room, because it lives here."

"Erin—"

"And the reason it lives here," she said, "is that I have worked out what I actually can't stand, and it is not you. It's that I have got exactly the same thing in me. I stood in that pharmacy in Skipton for eleven days on my own and I brought out paracetamol. Boxes of it. Because I was frightened of hurting." She was almost smiling and it was terrible. "There were four shelves of amoxicillin eighteen inches from my head for eleven days, and I

left them, and if I had brought out one box, one, Wendy Ashraf is alive and none of the rest of it happens."

She went in.

. . . .

They stayed together for the whole of the rest of it, and it was, in its way, closer than before, and everyone who was there would have told you they were fine.

They were kind to each other. They divided the watches so as to be on together. In May, on a good day, on the tops above Arncliffe, she taught him the names of eleven plants and he taught her, God help them both, how a range review works, and they laughed a great deal, and that evening she put her head on his shoulder by a fire.

And there was a room in it now that neither of them went into, and both of them knew where the door was, and the door had *Wendy Ashraf* written on it in Erin's handwriting and *the orchard* written underneath in his.

Sandhu, who missed nothing, said one thing about it, four days later, on a wall.

"You want to sort that."

"There isn't a way to sort it."

"No," Sandhu agreed. "There isn't. But you want to sort it anyway, because I'll tell you what happens otherwise." She looked out over the dale. "One of you dies with it still stood in the room, and the other one keeps it. And then it's not a thing between two people any more. It's just a thing you've got, for good, on your own."

Cowie has been carrying that sentence for eleven months.

NINETEEN

DRAYCOTT

They were found in July, which is the right way round: nobody finds Draycott.

By July they were in a bad way and had stopped being able to see it, which is what fifteen months does. They had been walking or holing up since March. They had lost, in that time, the farm, the seed, the dog, the hen, four coats, the axe, Feeley, and eleven pounds each. Nadia had a cough that came back every third week. Sandhu had a tooth that she would not let Erin look at. Cowie had stopped keeping the chart in February and had not told anybody, and had gone on doing the count out loud at supper from memory, which he had been getting wrong since May.

The riders came up the track above Litton at about eleven in the morning: two of them, on actual horses, wearing actual hi-vis, and one of them said, "Morning. Are you all right for water?"

Cowie began to laugh and could not stop, and had to sit down in the road.

. . .

Draycott Hall is eleven miles from anywhere, in a bowl of ground with one road in, and it had been a wedding venue.

That is the joke that everybody there made in their first week and nobody made afterwards. A wedding venue: two hundred and forty acres,

a walled garden, a lake, a generator house, forty bedrooms, a marquee store, and a commercial kitchen built to do three hundred covers. It had been bought in the nineties by a family who had understood exactly one thing, which was that people will pay a very great deal of money to have a nice day in a nice place, and the family had installed, over thirty years, everything a settlement of two hundred people needs, for entirely different reasons.

There were two hundred and eleven people at Draycott in July.

They had a school. That is what Cowie remembers walking into. There were sixty children in a converted stable block being taught in three groups by four adults, and there was a wall of paintings, and there was a timetable on a whiteboard with subjects on it, and Nadia stood in the doorway of that room holding an empty cat carrier and did not move for about a minute and a half.

They had power for four hours a night off two hydro turbines in the beck.

They had a bakery. They had eleven acres of potatoes and a proper rotation and a man called Adeyemi who had been an agronomist. They had a laundry with a mangle, and a rule about socks, and a Tuesday market where nothing was bought or sold and things changed hands anyway.

They had a doctor. Her name was Ines Halloran and she had been a consultant physician in Preston, and on the second morning she looked at Sandhu's tooth and took it out in eleven minutes with lidocaine, actual lidocaine, and Sandhu came out into the courtyard afterwards and stood there with her hand against her jaw and cried, in front of everybody, for the first time since the A65.

. . .

They were assessed on the third day by a woman called Margaret Ollerenshaw, who chaired the committee, and who was about sixty and had been a headteacher, and whom Cowie liked immediately and

continued to like for a fortnight, which turned out to be exactly the intended duration.

"Five of you," she said, reading. "One child. What can you do?"

Sandhu said PE teacher and Erin said pharmacist and there was a small pause in the room at that, which Cowie noticed and filed and did not understand.

Hutch said, "I don't know."

"You're eighteen?"

"Nineteen."

"Then you can do everything," said Margaret Ollerenshaw, "and we'll find out what you're good at by Christmas." She wrote something. "And you?"

"I did category management," said Cowie. "For a supermarket."

She looked up. It was the first time her attention had properly come off the page.

"Say that again."

"Category management. Ranging, forecasting, allocation. I did the numbers." He heard how it sounded, in a room, in the second summer. "I ran the stores at the farm for fourteen months."

Margaret Ollerenshaw put her pen down and said, "Mr Cowie, we have two hundred and eleven people, four storerooms, a harvest coming and a man doing the ledger who used to be a driving instructor. Would you like a job?"

. . .

That fortnight is the happiest any of them had been since the first month at Hillfoot, and this time Cowie knew it was happening while it was happening, which he counts as growth.

He had an office. It was a bay window in what had been the bridal suite and it had a desk in it and a view of the lake, and he sat at that desk for six days and built Draycott a stock model, and on the seventh day he took it to the committee and told them that they were four hundred kilos of oats

short of March and that the answer was to stop feeding oats to the horses in January, and there was an argument, and he won it, and afterwards a man he had never met shook his hand in a corridor.

Erin worked with Halloran in the annexe and came back the first evening lit up in a way Cowie had not seen since before Hillfoot, because there was a *dispensary*, a real one, with a lock and a ledger and four hundred lines on the shelves, and because for the first time in fifteen months she was not the last word on anything.

Hutch went on the outer teams and was extremely good at it and started saying things twice again, in the second week, on a Thursday, and Sandhu heard it happen across a courtyard and had to go and stand behind the marquee store.

And Nadia went to school. She went to school. She came back on the first day with a piece of paper with a horse on it and she was cross about the horse, technically cross, about the legs, and she went to bed talking about a girl called Amara and did not mention the cat carrier, and it stayed under the bed that night and every night after, and none of the adults said one word about it to each other because none of them trusted themselves.

. . .

There were four things Cowie noticed in that fortnight and put down, at the time, as the ordinary strangeness of an institution.

The first was the badges. Everybody at Draycott wore a small enamel disc on the coat, dark green, about the size of a five pence piece, and there were three colours in circulation and nobody had explained the difference, and when he asked, a woman in the bakery said, "Oh, that's just the assessments," and turned round to the oven.

The second was the bell. It went twice in the fortnight, both times in the afternoon, and both times every person in sight of him stopped what they were doing and stood still, and looked at nothing, for about thirty seconds, and then went on. Nobody explained that either. Hutch asked a

lad on his team and the lad said, "It's a mark of respect," and would not say what for.

The third was that the annexe had a door onto the courtyard that was locked from the outside, and Erin, who worked in the annexe every day, had not been given a key to it, and Halloran had said, pleasantly, that keys came at six months.

And the fourth was the thing Cowie noticed on the eleventh day, in his own ledgers, in the bay window, with the lake outside.

Draycott was two hundred and eleven people. He had the food model, so he had the population, so he had the movements, and he was reconciling the quarterly numbers because the driving instructor had not carried a figure over.

In the previous twelve months, Draycott had taken in ninety-four people.

In the same twelve months, Draycott had recorded nineteen deaths.

And the population had gone from two hundred and eleven to two hundred and eleven.

THE REGISTER

Two hundred and eleven, plus ninety-four, minus nineteen, is two hundred and eighty-six.

Cowie sat in the bay window with the lake outside and did it four times, on paper, and then went and got the previous year's book and did that one too, and the previous year had the same shape, and the shape was seventy-five people wide.

He did what he had always done, which was to assume it was the feed.

He raised it, in effect, with data services. He went and found the driving instructor, whose name was Ron, and said, in the friendliest voice he had, that he thought there might be a reconciliation problem in the population lines, and Ron went a colour that Cowie had last seen on a man in a front garden on Cardigan Road and said, "That's not mine. That's committee. Movements out is committee," and got up and left the room.

. . .

Erin came and found him that night before he had gone looking for her, and that is the fact he holds on to out of the whole of Draycott.

She came into the bay window at about eleven with the power off and a candle in a jam jar, which was the old arrangement, and put it on the desk between them and said:

"There's a woman in the annexe called Beryl Naismith and she's for Thursday."

"For Thursday."

"That's the phrase. It's on the board. There's a whiteboard in the back office and it's got four names on it and a day against each one." She sat down on the edge of the desk. "I asked Halloran what it meant and she told me. She didn't lie, Neil, she didn't even hesitate. She got me a chair first."

He waited.

"They worked it out in the first autumn," said Erin. "Halloran did. Same as H.K., about a fortnight later, on her own, off two deaths in a house with no bites in it. Everybody gets up. It isn't the bite, it's dying, it doesn't matter how."

"I know."

"So then they had a policy problem." She said the words *policy problem* the way you would hold something at arm's length. "Because if everybody gets up, then every single death in this place is an incident, and an incident in a walled settlement with sixty children in it is not survivable twice. So the policy is: no unattended death. Somebody is with you when you die, and they do the necessary thing within a minute, and it is done kindly and it is done every time."

"That's not wrong," said Cowie.

"No," said Erin. "That's not wrong. That's what we'd have done. That's what any of us would have done and I'd have argued for it." She was very steady. "The next bit is the bit."

. . . .

The next bit was assessment.

If no death may be unattended, then a death that cannot be predicted is a hazard, and a settlement that is serious about the policy has to know who is likely to die. So there is an assessment, four times a year, by Halloran, of every person at Draycott, and the outcome of the assessment is a badge, and the badges are green, and amber, and there is a third colour that

nobody wears in public because people on the third colour are in the annex.

And then, because assessment is imprecise and because people die at three in the morning in their own beds, the policy had acquired, over eighteen months, by a series of individually reasonable committee decisions, a final clause.

Where a person's death is assessed as probable within the quarter, the attendance is scheduled.

"They put them to sleep," said Erin. "On a Thursday. With Halloran there and a member of committee and a relative if there is one, and they do it properly, they do it better than anything you or I have ever done for anybody, there's a room and it's warm and there's music if you want it. Beryl Naismith is eighty-one and she has heart failure and she has known since March, and she has chosen Thursday, and she chose it herself, and she is looking forward to seeing her husband, and I sat with her for an hour this afternoon and she held my hand and told me I looked tired."

Cowie said, "And the seventy-five."

"What seventy-five?"

He turned the ledger round and showed her.

Erin looked at the three lines of arithmetic for a long time.

"Attendances aren't deaths," she said slowly. "That's it, isn't it. That's what Halloran said and I didn't hear it. She said *nineteen deaths last year, which is very low for a population this size, and we're proud of it*. Because an attendance isn't a death, it's a procedure, and it goes in a different book."

"There's a different book."

"There'll be a different book," said Erin. "There's always a different book. You've written half of them."

. . .

He found it in four days, and he found it because he was the man they had given a job to, and because a man doing a reconciliation is the most invisible object in any institution.

The Register was not hidden. It was in the committee room in a cupboard with the minutes, and it was a hardback A4 book with a green cover, and it had been kept beautifully. Name, date of arrival, quarterly assessment, date of attendance, attending clinician, witness, and a final column, ruled and headed in Margaret Ollerenshaw's own handwriting: WISHES RESPECTED.

Cowie read seventy-five entries in that room in one sitting.

About half of them were Beryl Naismith. Old, ill, dying, informed, consenting, and dealt with by people who had gone to some trouble. There is not a thing in the world he can say against those and he has stopped trying.

Then there were the others.

There was a man of forty-four who had come in during the second winter with a chest infection and been amber at his first assessment and attended eleven days after arrival. There was a woman with an ulcer on her leg. There were four entries in one week in February of that year, all of them arrivals from the same group, all of them assessed on the day they came in, all attended within a fortnight, and against every one of them in the last column, in the same handwriting, on the same afternoon, the words *wishes respected*.

And there was a boy of nine, in the previous September, with a note in the assessment column that said *recurrent resp. infection, poor prognosis over winter, mother informed*.

Cowie put the book back in the cupboard and went out and sat on the steps by the lake and was sick into a rose bed.

. . . .

Nadia's assessment was on the eleventh of August.

She had had the cough for three days by then, the one that came back every third week and had come back every third week since February, and Halloran listened to her chest for a long time and was extremely kind, and

asked whether it had been like this last winter, and Nadia, who was eight and honest, said yes, and worse.

She came out into the courtyard with a badge in her hand and gave it to Sandhu because she did not want to put it on.

It was amber.

Sandhu stood in the middle of the courtyard at Draycott Hall holding a small enamel disc, with the school windows open behind her and sixty children doing a song in three parts, and Cowie watched her face go through the whole of it, all fifteen months, the A65 and the Transit and the top field and the night on the bank and the gateway below Kirkby Malham.

Then she said, "Right."

And that was that decided.

THE BARN

The plan was Sandhu's and it was four sentences long, and Cowie argued against it for two days and lost, and it was the right plan.

"We can't walk out," she said. "Six of us walked in and one of them's registered, and the minute we ask for the gate they'll want to know why, and then we're four people arguing with two hundred about a book we've read in a cupboard. So we're not asking for the gate. We're going to make it so they can't shut it."

"How?"

"You're going to tell them," said Sandhu.

. . .

Draycott held a general meeting on the last Tuesday of the month, in the marquee store, and about a hundred and sixty people came to it, because there was tea.

Cowie went up to the front with a ledger under his arm.

He has been asked what he felt and the honest answer is that he felt exactly what he had felt in Nidd. He had two hundred and six pages once and he had a green hardback book now, and the shape of the job was identical: you have the numbers, and the room does not want them, and you go anyway.

He read out three lines of arithmetic first, because you always lead with the thing that cannot be argued with. Two hundred and eleven. Ninety-four in. Nineteen deaths. And a settlement that had not grown by one person in two years.

Then he read the Register.

Not all of it. He read the man of forty-four with the chest infection, attended eleven days after arrival. He read the four in one week in February with the same handwriting and the same afternoon. He read the woman with the ulcer on her leg. And then he stopped and said that he was not going to read the last one out because there were children in the room, and that anybody who wanted to could come and look at the entry for the fourteenth of September, and that it was a boy of nine.

The marquee store was completely silent.

And then Margaret Ollerenshaw stood up, and did the bravest and worst thing Cowie has ever watched anybody do, which was to agree with every word of it.

. . .

"He is right," she said. "Every figure he has read out is correct, and I signed all of them, and I would like to explain why, and then you may do as you think best."

She was superb. That is the thing nobody who was not there believes.

She talked for about six minutes without a note. She said that everybody in the room knew what happens to a person who dies. She said that in the first winter, before the policy, Draycott had lost eleven people in one night in the west wing because an old man had died in his sleep at the end of a corridor with a fire door propped open, and that four of the eleven had been children, and that she could name them and would if anybody wanted her to. She said that the policy that came out of that night had been agreed by a full meeting in this room and that some of the people who had voted for it were sitting in it now.

And then she said the sentence that Cowie has never got out from under.

"Mr Cowie has told you what we do," she said. "He has not told you what he proposes instead. So I will ask him, and I would like everybody to listen to the answer. Mr Cowie: a man in this settlement is going to die in the next month, of something in his chest, at a time nobody can predict, in a building with other people asleep in it. What would you like us to do?"

Cowie stood there in front of a hundred and sixty people with a green book in his hands.

"I don't know," he said.

"No," said Margaret Ollerenshaw, not unkindly. "Nor did we, for a winter. And eleven people died of not knowing, and I have to tell you that four of them were—"

"But you're not doing that any more," said Erin, from the middle of the room.

She had not stood up. She stood up now.

"You started with the man who is definitely going to die in the next month," she said, "and I would sit with that man on a Thursday and hold his hand and I'd think you were right. But you're not on that any more, because that isn't a hard problem, and committees don't stop. You're on a woman with a leg ulcer. You're on people you've had for eleven days. You're on *a badge on a child with a cough*, because she coughs in the winter, like every child who has ever lived through a winter." She was shaking and her voice was not. "You've not got a policy about dying. You've got a policy about not being frightened, and it eats a bit more every quarter, and next year it will be somebody in this tent who is in perfectly good health and simply old."

That was when the meeting stopped being a meeting.

. . .

It split about seventy-thirty against the committee, which is to say it split, which is to say that by nine o'clock that night Draycott Hall had two

hundred people in it who had each decided something different and there was shouting in the courtyard and somebody had taken the whiteboard out of the annexe and broken it over a wall.

Sandhu had the five of them at the gate in the dark with the bags on at ten past nine, exactly as she had said they would be, because a place that is arguing with itself is not watching its gate.

They were four hundred yards down the drive when the shot went.

It was not aimed at them. It was not, as far as anybody has ever established, aimed at anyone; there were two men on the gate and one of them was on the committee and one of them was not, and there had been a struggle for a rifle in the dark, and a rifle that is being struggled for goes off.

Erin said, "Oh," in a small surprised voice, and sat down in the middle of the drive.

. . . .

It had gone through the muscle at the top of her left thigh and out, missing everything that would have finished it in four minutes and hitting nothing that would mend on its own.

Cowie got the belt on. He was very fast and very calm and he got it on properly this time, and he had a mop handle, in the sense that he had a piece of the gate hurdle, and he turned it until she swore at him, and he held it, and Hutch got a dressing on and Sandhu held the lamp and Nadia stood four feet away with the cat carrier and did not make one single sound.

The bleeding slowed. The bleeding stopped.

And the five of them knelt in the dark on a gravel drive with a settlement coming apart behind them, and every one of the four adults did the same arithmetic at the same moment, and nobody said any of it out loud.

An open wound, through the muscle, dirty, in August, four hundred yards from the only functioning dispensary between here and the sea.

Erin, who had been a pharmacist for eleven years and had spent two years telling people what a dirty wound does, got her hand into Cowie's collar and pulled his head down until it was against hers, and said:

"Right. Listen to me very carefully, because I am about to be extremely brave and I have only got about a minute of it."

ERIN

"I'm going back in," she said.

"No."

"Neil, shut up, I've got a minute." Her hand was still in his collar. "There is one dispensary and it is four hundred yards that way and I know where the key is, because I have been in that room every day for six weeks. I can be treated. I am the only one of us who can walk in there and be treated, because I am the pharmacist and they need me, and Halloran will do it herself and she'll do it well."

"They'll put you on the book."

"Yes," said Erin. "They will."

Sandhu said, from behind the lamp, "Erin."

"Amber, probably. Open wound, August, no antibiotics for eighteen months before I got there." She was breathing carefully around it. "Which is fine, because amber is a badge, and badges get reassessed, and by the time the next quarter comes round that place will either have thrown the committee out or it won't, and if it hasn't then I will have had eight weeks in a warm room with a lock on the inside and I will have made my own arrangements, and you know that I will."

"And if you can't."

"Then I will have died of a leg in a building with electricity," said Erin Mowat, "instead of dying of a leg in a hedge in Wharfedale with all four of you sat round watching me do it, and the second one takes eleven days and

I have watched it happen to somebody I loved and I am not doing it in front of that child."

Nobody said anything.

"And there's the other thing," she said, "and I want it said out loud, because you'll all be very careful not to say it for about a year. Every hour you're stood here is an hour that gate is open and nobody's watching it. There are a hundred and sixty people in that tent having the argument of their lives about a book, and it will be over by midnight, and when it's over somebody will remember that there's a registered child a mile down that drive."

Sandhu stood up.

"Right," she said, and it came out in pieces.

. . .

They had four minutes, and Cowie is not going to write down most of it.

Some of it belongs to Hutch, who knelt down and put his forehead against her shoulder and said "no" about nine times and was got up by Sandhu.

Some of it belongs to Nadia, who came and stood over her and said, in a completely level voice, "Are you dying," and Erin said, "Not tonight," and Nadia said, "That's not the same as no," and Erin said, "No, love, it isn't, and I'm not going to lie to you, because your mum never did," and then Nadia put the cat carrier down on the gravel next to her and said, "You have it."

Erin took it. She had it with her when she went up the drive. It is the only object out of the whole of the two years that Cowie can still see in colour.

And some of it is Sandhu, who said the shortest thing and the only useful one: "I'll not let anything happen to her," meaning Nadia, and Erin said, "I know. That's why it's you," and that was the whole of their goodbye, two women who had walked four hundred miles together.

Then it was the two of them for about ninety seconds.

"Say it," said Erin.

"Say what?"

"Neil. Do not make me spend one of my four minutes."

So he said it. He got down on the gravel with his face against the side of her head and he said it properly, all of it, the thing that had been standing in the room since Halton Gill, and it came out badly and in the wrong order and it was the best work of his life.

He said that he had known about the orchard.

He said that he had known on the eighteenth of November, standing in that kitchen, that there was something wrong with what everybody believed about bites, and that he had had it in his hands and put it down, and that he had put it down because he was a man who gave people numbers so that the decision would belong to somebody else, and that he had been that man in a meeting room named after a river and he had been that man in a farmhouse kitchen and Wendy Ashraf was dead because of it.

He said that he was not asking her to say it was all right.

And Erin Mowat, who was thirty-four and grey to the lips and had about six weeks to live and did not know it, listened to the whole thing without interrupting once, and then said:

"Thank you."

Not *it's all right*. Not *it wasn't your fault*. She had eleven years of telling people the truth in a dispensary and she was not going to spend her last minute on a kindness that was not true.

"Thank you," she said. "That's the one I wanted." She got her hand up onto the back of his neck. "Now. The room's empty. All right? The thing's said and the room's empty and you are not to go back in there and shut the door behind you, because I know you and you will."

"Erin—"

"Promise me you'll be a nuisance," she said. "Not brave. You're not, and it's fine. A nuisance. Stand up in tents. It's the only thing you're any good at and it is worth more than the rest of us put together."

Then she said, "Go on. Before I stop."

. . . .

She went up the drive on Sandhu's shoulder as far as the turn, and they stood her against the gatepost, and she got the cat carrier into her right hand and lifted her chin at the lamp in the courtyard, and Sandhu came back down the drive at a dead run and did not look round, and neither did Cowie, because Erin had told him not to and because he had promised her one thing in his life and it was going to be that one.

Halloran treated her that night. They know that much. It came out through Denny Hargreaves's people fourteen months later in the way that everything came out eventually, four hundred miles of gossip carried by men with barrows.

She was on the Register within a week, amber, and she was reassessed in the October quarter and taken off it, and she worked in that dispensary for five and a half years.

Cowie did not know any of that for fourteen months. He walked out of Wharfedale in August of the second year believing he had left her to die on a gravel drive, and he was wrong, and there is nothing anybody can do about the fourteen months.

THE COST

They came out of Wharfedale in the last week of August with four people, three bags and a rifle they had not fired, and they went east, which was the direction on the leaflet, which was the direction Cowie had been refusing for sixteen months.

Sandhu put it to a vote on the second morning, which was a formality and a kindness.

"Harrogate," she said.

Hutch said, "Aye," once.

Nadia said, "Is there a school?"

And Cowie, who had walked away from four dots on a map in April of the first year because everybody else was walking towards them, said, "Yes," and did not know whether he was lying.

. . .

There is nothing to tell about the walk. It took nine days and it was the easiest journey any of them ever made, and that is the joke of the whole thing.

The country in the second August was not the country of the first. The roads were clear. There were fewer of them, and the ones there were had stopped being a herd and become a scatter, standing in gateways and stood at the edges of fields, and you could walk a mile of open road in daylight

and see four and be seen by none. The dead do not eat. That is the thing that had been true from the first week and that nobody had had the nerve to say out loud: they had been walking about the north of England for two years and eight months on nothing at all, and by the second autumn a great many of them had simply stopped, the way a clock stops, and were standing in the rain going quietly to bits.

They saw people on that walk. They saw a family of six with a handcart on the Blubberhouses road and both parties waved and neither stopped. They saw smoke, twice, and went round it, out of habit, and Sandhu said on the second occasion that she thought they might be past that now and did not suggest turning back.

Cowie walked the nine days and did the arithmetic he had been doing since the drive.

It was not a chart. He tried it as a chart on the third night with a pencil and it would not go. What he had instead was a list that got longer every time he made himself say it, and it went: Jo. Emeka Ogunremi and Ruth and whatever was upstairs at number 47. His mother, at the end of a taped-off road, never confirmed, which after two and a half years is its own kind of confirmed. Deb from finance and a graduate in a very good jacket. Sue Ellerby, who had gone up to do the roof plant because there was nobody else who knew how to isolate it. Tom Shackleton, twice. Wendy Ashraf, who had asked for one thing in seven months. Dermot Feeley, under a wall below Kirkby Malham with a story about a carpet still in him. A dog that would not come out from under the parlour steps. And Erin Mowat, going up a gravel drive on somebody else's shoulder with an empty cat carrier in her right hand.

He got to the end of the list on the fourth night and started it again, because there was nothing else to do with his head between six and nine, and by the ninth day he had it in an order.

That is what it cost. There is not a better way of putting it. Four people arrived at the Reception outside Harrogate in September of the second year, out of eight who had stood in a yard at Skipton in April of the first, and the four of them were alive because of a laminated sheet on a parlour

door, a boy who went back through a window for a cat carrier, a man who walked out at eleven at night to tell his enemies the truth, and a woman who went back up a drive on purpose.

None of it was Cowie's chart. He would like that in.

. . .

Reception was a retail park.

They had put the fence round the whole of it, the units and the car park and the drive-through, and they had the barrier where the exit had been, and there was a queue, and the queue moved, and there were nine people processing at trestle tables under the canopy of a garden centre.

It took four hours. There was a form.

There was an actual form, A4, both sides, with a box for previous occupation and a box that said REASON FOR PRESENTING and eleven tick boxes underneath it, and Cowie stood in a queue on a September afternoon in the second year of the world being over and filled in a form, and when he got to previous occupation he wrote *category management (grocery)* and the man behind the trestle table looked at it and looked up and said:

"Numbers?"

"Numbers," said Cowie.

The man wrote something on a card and said, "You'll not be sweeping, then," which turned out to be wrong, and handed him a wristband and a leaflet.

The leaflet was the same leaflet. Same two colours. Same map with no roads on it. They had run off two hundred thousand of them in the second week of the Handover and they were still using them up.

. . .

Nadia went into the school on the fourth day. There was a school. It was two units of a retail park with the shelving still in them and a hundred and

ten children and four teachers, and one of the teachers was called Amara's mother, which is a story that belongs to Nadia and not to this.

Sandhu got put on a work party and lasted eleven days before somebody in a hi-vis worked out what she was and made her a supervisor, which she accepted on condition that nobody ever used the word.

Hutch turned twenty in the November and went onto the outer teams.

And in October, in a room with a strip light in it and a woman with a clipboard and a laminated card, Neil Cowie sat down and was assessed for Adjustment, and the woman asked him whether he had experienced any loss, and he opened his mouth to give her the list in the order he had it, and heard himself say:

"Some."

He has thought about that since, at length, on landings, in stairwells, with a door chocked open behind him.

He went out afterwards and stood in a car park in Harrogate in the rain and got the leaflet out of his inside pocket, the original one, the one out of the hedge on the seventh day, soft as cloth by then and coming apart along the folds, and read the sentence about the final phase for about the four hundredth time.

Then he put it back in his pocket, because he was not going to throw it away, and he went to find out where they wanted him in the morning.

WELLINGTON STREET

The building had been called Waterloo House. Someone at Harrogate had drawn a line through that on the sector map and written 6/WEL/04 above it in a hand that sloped backwards, because the Executive had determined in its second month that names were a vector for sentiment and sentiment was slowing the work.

Cowie had liked the name. It was on a brass plate by the revolving door, and the plate had been polished by a man who came on Tuesdays, and Cowie thought about that man more than he thought about most of the people he had actually known.

He did not tell the unit that he had worked in it. He had four opportunities on the walk in and he took none of them, and he has never been able to give himself a reason that survives contact with daylight.

. . . .

They cleared from the top. This was doctrine, arrived at expensively. You went up the stairwell in the dark with the door of each landing chocked behind you, and you started at the roof and came down through the building like water finding its way, and anything that was still standing had nowhere to go but down into the lobby where Sandhu waited with the shotgun and a folding stool she had taken from a pub on Boar Lane and would not be parted from.

They did the roof first. There is plant up there, chillers and a housing and a steel walkway, and Hutch went round it twice with the lamp and came back and said, "Nothing. Nothing," and Cowie stood at the parapet for a moment looking down at the multi-storey where his car had been on the fourth level, and did not say anything at all.

Floor six was open plan. It had been open plan in the way that meant somebody had paid a consultancy to remove the walls and then paid a second consultancy to install a quantity of felt.

"Grid it," said Sandhu, on the radio, from her stool, four floors below.

"Gridding it," said Hutch, who was twenty-one and still said everything twice, once to the radio and once to himself, as though the first version had been for the record and the second was the true account.

The desks ran in banks of six. Every one of them had been left mid-sentence. That was the thing about the office blocks that the residential streets did not have, because a house was where people had gone to make their decisions and an office was where they had simply stopped: a cardigan on the back of a chair, a Pret bag gone to a brown paste inside its own carbon, a screen with a spreadsheet still open on it under three years of dust, the cursor blinking in cell F41 for eleven months until the building's power finally went and it stopped blinking and became simply a mark.

Bank four, third desk in, facing the multi-storey.

Somebody had been about to type a number. Cowie stood over his own chair with a lamp in his hand and looked at the last thing he had ever done for money, and found that he could not remember what the number was for.

The glass boxes were along the north wall. Wharfe, Aire, Calder. The marker pens were still in the tray under the whiteboard in Nidd and there was writing on the board, in his own hand, four bullet points and an arrow, and one of the bullets said *11cm* and had been underlined twice.

He stood in the doorway of that room for a while.

Then he went back out and gridded bank five, because there was a floor to do and a woman on a folding stool four storeys down who had been sitting in the dark since eight.

They found her in the accessible toilet. They were nearly always in a small room. Harrogate had produced a paper about this, sixteen pages with a foreword, and had concluded that the behaviour was consistent with a terminal impulse toward enclosure, which was the Executive all over: sixteen pages to say that when people got frightened they went and shut a door.

She was standing between the basin and the wall. Non-viable, in the language of the sector maps. Nivs, in the language of everybody who had ever actually stood in a room with one. She was wearing a lanyard, and the lanyard had her photograph on it, and in the photograph she was laughing at somebody just off to the left of the camera.

She had been in the building for thirty years. She knew where the stopcocks were, and which of the fire doors on four had been sticking since 2009, and she had gone up to isolate the roof plant on the last Thursday because there was nobody else who knew how, and Cowie had stood at a lift with his coat on and his bag on his shoulder and said *see you tomorrow, then*.

He did it. There was a way of doing it that the training films called controlled and that the unit called getting on with it, and it took under two seconds.

Then he did the other part, which was the part the training films did not have footage of, because there was no footage of it anywhere and there never would be. He turned the lanyard over and wrote the name in the book.

S. Ellerby.

He looked at it for a moment. Then he wrote, in the column headed OTHER, the word *Sue*, and closed the book, because the column headed OTHER was the only place in the entire architecture of the National Recovery Executive where a person could put down a thing they had noticed.

. . . .

The forms went to Harrogate in a bag on a Thursday. Nobody in the unit had ever met anybody who had read one, and there was a standing theory, which Sandhu held with real conviction, that the forms went into a room and the room was full and there was a second room being prepared.

The tabards were sponsored. This was the detail that visitors could never get past, in the days when there had been visitors. Somebody at Harrogate, in the first autumn, at a point when the actual clearance of the actual cities had not yet begun, had signed a memorandum of understanding with the Pennine Mutual Building Society, and so the high-visibility tabard worn by every sweeper in every cordon in the north of England carried, across the shoulder blades, in a font the society had commissioned in 2011 to convey approachability, the words *PENNINE MUTUAL: HERE FOR THE LONG RUN*.

You stopped seeing it. That was the thing about it, and it was the thing about all of it. Hutch, who had been seventeen at the Handover and had therefore done his growing up inside the new arrangements, did not think the tabards were funny at all, and could not be made to think so, and had once asked with genuine puzzlement why a building society would not sponsor the sweep, and Cowie had opened his mouth to explain and had discovered that he could not get to the bottom of it either.

They were all being adjusted. That was the term, and it had come loose from its moorings the way words did now and had turned into an adjective and then into a joke and then into the ordinary way of saying that somebody was having a bad afternoon. *He's adjusting*. Sandhu said it about Hutch. Hutch said it about Cowie. Cowie said it about nobody, because he had noticed that he only ever said it about people he had decided to stop looking at properly.

. . . .

He had known for eleven months that Erin Mowat was alive.

It had come the way everything came, four hundred miles of gossip carried by men with barrows: Denny Hargreaves's people to a market at Otley, Otley to a work party, a work party to a woman in the kitchens at Reception who knew Sandhu, and Sandhu across a canteen table on an ordinary Tuesday, going white, holding a mug, saying his name twice before she could say the rest of it.

Amber, in the August. Reassessed and taken off it in the October. Working in that dispensary ever since, with a lock on the inside of the door and, according to the third-hand version, a considerable amount to say about how the place was now run, the committee having been thrown out in the November by a general meeting in a marquee store.

He had written to her once. It went with a man going west in the spring and it was four pages and he does not know whether it arrived, because that is how the post works now: you give it to somebody, and you do not find out.

He could go. That is the thing he has to sit with. It is nine days on foot and he has done nine days on foot with a rifle he could not use and a child he could not feed, and he is thirty-five and healthy and there is a road.

He has not gone.

Sandhu asked him about it once, on the stairs at Quarry Hill, and he gave her about four reasons and she let him finish all of them and then said, "Aye, and?" and he stood there on a landing with a lamp in his hand and told her the true one, which was that Erin Mowat had spent eleven days in a dispensary in Skipton with four shelves of amoxicillin eighteen inches from her head and had come out carrying paracetamol, and had never once forgiven herself for it, and that he had watched what that did to a person over sixteen months.

"And you've got yours," said Sandhu.

"I've got mine."

"And you'd rather have it here."

"I'd rather have it here," said Cowie, "than take it nine days west and put it on the table in front of the one person who'd know exactly what it was."

Sandhu thought about that for a while.

"That's the most honest thing you've ever said," she said, "and it's still cowardice, and you know that as well."

"Yes."

"Right," said Sandhu, and picked her stool up. "Well. Nadia's fifteen in March. She's been asking."

. . . .

"Six is clear," said Hutch, to the radio, and then, to himself, to the felt, to the banner, to the eleven centimetres of shelf in a shop on the other side of a cordon that was not going to be reopened in his lifetime, "six is clear."

They chocked the door and went down to seven, which was the wrong direction, but the stairwell at the north end had gone in the winter and the only way to seven was to come at it from beneath, and so the building was cleared out of order, which was not doctrine, and would have to be written up, and would go in the bag on Thursday, and would be read by nobody in a room that was filling up.

Cowie went last.

At the landing he stopped and put his head back through the door and looked down the length of floor six, at the banks of desks and the felt and the brown paste and the screen with its unfinished number, and at the glass box on the north wall with four bullet points still on the board, and at the far end, above the lift lobby, at the banner.

It said HAPPY RETIREMENT SUE, in letters that had been individually gold and had, in the damp, become individually green.

And he thought that the honest thing, the thing that Harrogate would never write on any form and that he would never put in the column marked OTHER, was that Sue Ellerby had made it to her retirement.

She had been in the building thirty years and she had got the card and the banner and the eleven centimetres of everybody's attention, and then she had had three years of standing quietly in a small room with the door shut, which was, he understood, on the balance of the evidence, and by the standards currently obtaining, quite a long retirement.